

CM launches Jan Kalyan Shivirs at 42 locations across national Capital

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Thursday inaugurated a Jan Kalyan Shivir at the MCD Community Hall in Sandesh Vihar, Shalimar Bagh. The camp was the first of 42 such welfare camps being held across all districts of Delhi from June 18 to 20, designed to bring Central and Delhi Government scheme benefits under one roof for citizens. Meanwhile, Delhi Assembly Speaker Vijender Gupta separately inaugurated a parallel camp in Rohini. The camps run daily from 10 am to 5 pm at all 42 locations and have been organ-

ised under the theme “12 Years of Trust, Development and Public Welfare.” MLA from Tri Nagar Tilak Ram Gupta was present at the Sandesh Vihar launch.

The Chief Minister said that earlier, Delhi residents had to visit different offices to access the benefits of various schemes, with many facilities remaining unavailable to them for years. She said the present Government is now reaching people at their doorstep with what she described as a resolve of service, convenience, and solutions, under a double-engine Government and a triple-engine system dedicated to public service.

Eligible beneficiaries can access information, assistance, and registration facilities for various schemes from different departments at a single location. Separate counters have been set up by departments, including the Delhi Jal Board and the House Tax Department, to provide assistance without causing inconvenience. The Chief Minister appealed to residents to visit their nearest Jan Kalyan Shivir with the required documents and avail themselves of the benefits on offer.

The camps offer access to a wide range of services. These include Pink Cards, Ration Cards, e-Shram Cards,



Jan Dhan Accounts, the Lakhpati Bitiya Yojana, the PM-UDAY Scheme, the PM SVANidhi Scheme, Aadhaar registration, the Talent Hunt Hauslon Ki Udaan programme, the Rashtriya

Vayoshri Yojana, House Tax services, information on the PM Surya Ghar Yojana for solar power, and loan facilities for MSMEs and industries. Saplings are being distributed under the Ek Ped

Maa Ke Naam campaign. Assistance is also available for scholarships, higher education support, and caste certificates for Scheduled Caste and Scheduled Tribe members, along with the Pradhan Mantri Matru Vandana Yojana, the Widow Daughter Marriage Assistance Scheme, regularisation of Delhi Jal Board water connections under LPSC, record updates for widows and persons with disabilities, and issuance of Ayushman Cards for senior citizens above 70 and BPL card holders.

At the separate Rohini camp, inaugurated at Rana Pratap Sarvodaya Kanya Vidyalaya in Sector 5, Speaker

Vijender Gupta said the camp reflects the government's commitment to ensuring citizens can access welfare schemes without unnecessary procedural difficulties. He described the camp as a comprehensive service platform offering facilities related to ration cards, e-Shram cards, Jan Dhan accounts, the Lakhpati Didi Yojana, Ayushman Bharat, PM Ujjwala Yojana, PM Vishwakarma Yojana, disability welfare schemes, and pension-related services.

Gupta said such outreach programmes strengthen the connection between Government institutions and citizens, with special atten-

tion given to women, senior citizens, persons with disabilities, workers, entrepreneurs, and economically weaker sections so that no eligible beneficiary is left out. He urged residents of Rohini and adjoining areas to actively participate and take advantage of the services on offer.

Both camps will remain operational through June 20, running in parallel with 40 other locations across Delhi's districts as part of the same coordinated outreach effort timed to coincide with the completion of 12 years of the Modi Government and reinforced by the Delhi government's own welfare delivery push since taking office.

Delhi Assembly forms 32 House committees for 2026-27

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Assembly Secretariat, on the directions of Speaker Vijender Gupta, has constituted 32 House committees for 2026-27. Speaker Gupta will chair five House Committees, while Deputy Speaker Mohan Singh Bisht will head three, an official statement announced on Thursday.

Opposition AAP MLAs Gopal Rai and Pravesh Ratn will chair the committee on papers laid on the table and the committee on delegated legislation, respectively.

All the remaining panels are headed by the ruling BJP MLAs, according to the statement from the Delhi Assembly Secretariat.

The youngest MLA in the House, Umang Bajaj (32), will chair the department related standing committee on education (covering education, higher education, training, art, culture, and sports). Bajaj is the BJP MLA from Rajinder Nagar constituency.

Both the BJP and opposition AAP MLAs have been given proportional repre-



sentation in the panels, according to the statement.

The Delhi Assembly speaker will chair the business advisory, private members' bills and resolutions, rules, general purposes, and library committees.

Deputy Speaker Bisht will head the committee on Government assurances, the questions and references committee, and the committee on peace and harmony.

The committee of privileges will be chaired by BJP MLA Pradyumn Singh Rajput. Its members will include Abhay Kumar Verma, Ajay

Kumar Mahawar, Neeraj Basoya, Ravi Kant, Satish Upadhyay, Surya Prakash Khatri, all BJP MLAs, and AAP MLAs Ram Singh Netaji and Surendra Kumar.

The specialised House — committee on violation of protocol norms and contemptuous behaviour by Government officers with MLAs — will be chaired by BJP MLA and former minister Kailash Gahlot.

The committee on the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) will operate under the chairmanship of BJP MLA Om Prakash Sharma.

MLA Karnail Singh will head the committee on the welfare of transgenders and persons with disabilities. Its members include Anil Goyal, Harish Khurana, Kailash Gahlot, Kailash Gangwal, Manoj Kumar Shokeen, Prem Chauhan, Shikha Roy, and Virender Singh Kadian.

The committee on issues related to unauthorised colonies will be headed by Kuldeep Solanki, while Deepak Chaudhary will chair the committee on the welfare of students and youth.

Speaker Gupta stated that these committees will immensely benefit the legislative process, ensuring rigorous oversight and structured deliberation on matters of public welfare.

He also expressed hope that the committees would make meaningful recommendations and contribute significantly towards addressing the aspirations and concerns of the people of Delhi.

The Delhi Assembly, having a membership of 70, comprises 48 BJP and 22 AAP MLAs.

Ex-Agniveers to get 20 per cent reservation in Group C posts: LG

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu on Thursday directed 20 per cent reservation for ex-Agniveers in group ‘C’ posts of police constables, firemen, forest guards, jail warders and wildlife guards.

Setting a firm operational timeline, the Lt Governor issued a strict deadline of June 30th for all concerned departments to finalise the required processes and implement the necessary amendments to their respective Recruitment Rules. All concerned departments have a June 20 deadline to complete the necessary processes and amendments to recruitment rules, he said.

Sandhu reviewed the strategy for extending reservation benefits to ex-Agniveers (retired short service Army personnel) across various Government departments and agencies in Delhi during a meeting with the chief secretary and Delhi Police Commissioner



and other senior officers. Delhi Chief Secretary Rajeev Verma and Police Commissioner Satish Golcha and other senior officers were present in the meeting.

This initiative is being implemented in accordance with the guiding vision of the Government of India, Sandhu said in a post on X.

“To effectively harness the discipline, skills, and training of these young men and women, directed the implementation of a 20 per cent reservation in direct recruitment to vacant Group ‘C’ posts, including Police Constables, Firemen, Jail Warders, Forest Guards, and Wildlife Guards,” the LG said.

Group C posts are non-gazetted positions. He said

recruitment will be open to all eligible ex-Agniveers to ensure equal opportunity and recognise their service to the nation. Sandhu had proposed recruitments of former Agniveers to the Delhi Fire Service in a meeting held on June 8.

The departments have further been empowered to deploy and utilise the specialised capabilities of these recruits in line with their operational requirements, he added. Agniveer scheme is the new recruitment system introduced by the Government of India for the Indian Army, Navy, and Air Force. Under the scheme, eligible candidates are enrolled as Agniveers for a fixed period of four years.

₹5 lakh aid for Malviya Nagar fire hero, Govt to bear treatment cost

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Government on Thursday provided financial assistance of ₹5 lakh and announced to bear the entire cost of treatment of a man who saved lives in the Malviya Nagar fire. In the tragic incident earlier this month, 23 persons died while over two dozen were injured. Chief Minister Rekha Gupta sent a “heartfelt” letter to Rohit Mukhiya, appreciating his sense of duty and compassion in the face of danger, said a Delhi CMO statement.

The chief minister in the letter saluted the courage and humanity of Mukhiya, a resident of Khirki Extension, who risked his life to save several people in the fire incident, it said. The chief minister has sanctioned an ex-gratia assistance of ₹5 lakh for him and also assured him that the Delhi Government will bear all medical expenses until his complete recovery, it said.

 सेन्ट्रल बैंक ऑफ इंडिया Central Bank of India		Regional Office Delhi (North) 1398, First Floor, Chandni Chowk, Delhi-110006		E-AUCTION SALE NOTICE (Under SARFAESI Act 2002)			
1911 से आपके लिए "सेन्ट्रल" "CENTRAL" TO YOU SINCE 1911							
APPENDIX- IV-A [SEE PROVISO TO RULE 8(6) & 9(1) SALE NOTICE FOR SALE OF IMMOVABLE PROPERTIES							
E-Auction Sale Notice for sale of Immovable Assets under the Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 read with proviso to Rule 8(6) & 9(1) of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002.							
Notice is hereby given to the public in general and in particular to the borrower(s) and guarantor(s) that the below described immovable property mortgaged / charged to the Central Bank of India (secured creditor), the constructive/ physical Possession of which have been taken by the authorized officer of Central Bank of India(Secured creditors), will be sold on "As is where is", "As is what is" and "whatever there is" basis on date 08.07.2026 for recovery of dues to the Central Bank of India from below mention Borrower(s) and Guarantor(s). The Reserve Price and Earnest money deposit (EMD) is displayed against the details of respective properties.							
E-AUCTION SCHEDULED TO BE HELD ON 08.07.2026 (15 DAY'S NOTICE)							
S. No.	Name of Branch	Authorised Officer / B.M.	Name of the Account	Description of Property & Owner Name	Demand Notice Date & Amount Dues (In Rupees)	Date & Type of Possession	In Rupees Reserve Price EMD Bid Increase
1.	Akshardham New Delhi	Mr. R. S. Mishra Mobile: 8800013551	PUJA ENTERPRISES	Shop No.318 Part of Old Office No 10, 11, 12 on Third Floor Property R-22 Out of Khasra No.473 Building Khaneja Complex Shakarpur Village Madawali Fazalpur Delhi-110092. Area 45 Sq Ft Owner : Dinesh Kumar Yadav	25.02.2020 Rs.54.84 Lakh + Other Charges Applicable Deductions/ Repayments	10.02.2023 (Physical)	₹ 3,15,000.00 ₹ 31,500.00 ₹ 10,000.00
2.	Akshardham New Delhi	Mr. R. S. Mishra Mobile: 8800013551	PUJA ENTERPRISES	Shop No.317 Part of Old Office No 10, 11, 12 on Third Floor property R-22 Out of Khasra No.473 Building Khaneja Complex Shakarpur Village Madawali Fazalpur Delhi-110092. Area 180 Sq Ft Owner : Dinesh Kumar Yadav	25.02.2020 Rs.54.84 Lakh + Other Charges Applicable Deductions/ Repayments	10.02.2023 (Physical)	₹ 12,50,000.00 ₹ 1,25,000.00 ₹ 15,000.00
3.	Sehani Ghaziabad	Mr. Abhay Mishra Mob: 8588907378	ANKUR AGGARWAL	Ground Floor Residential Flat, Plot No 36-A, Sham Nagar, Khureji Khas, Shahdara, Delhi-110051. Area 50.16 Sq Mtr Owner: Ankur Aggarwal	29.07.2019 Rs.11.48 Lakh + Other Charges Applicable Deductions/ Repayments	18.10.2019 (Physical)	₹ 17,10,000.00 ₹ 1,71,000.00 ₹ 20,000.00
4.	Sehani Ghaziabad	Mr. Abhay Mishra Mob: 8588907378	UDAIVIR SINGH	1st and 2nd Floor, Residential Flat on Plot No. A-68, Khasra No.389, Village- Ghonda Gurjan Khadar, Bhajanpura, Shahdara, New Delhi-110053. Area 611.83 SqFt. Owner: Udaivir Singh	11.05.2021 Rs.11.89 Lakh + Other Charges Applicable Deductions/ Repayments	21.03.2025 (Physical)	₹ 21,42,000.00 ₹ 2,14,200.00 ₹ 20,000.00
5.	Shyamal College Delhi	Ms. Radhika Mittal Mobile: 8800013543	M/S CLOUD NINE	2nd Floor, Residential Flat (Without Roof Rights) No.16/399-E, Padam Singh Road, Bapa Nagar, Karol Bagh, New Delhi-110005. Area 909 Sq Ft Owner: Mahmood Ansari	28.01.2019 Rs.49.71 Lakh + Other Charges Applicable Deductions/ Repayments	09.03.2021 (Physical)	₹ 26,25,000.00 ₹ 2,62,500.00 ₹ 25,000.00
6.	I T Park Usmanpur Delhi	Mr. Hussain Ali Mobile: 9568431985	RAM DARASH RAM	MIG Flat No GF-2 (Without Roof Rights), Plot No. B-12/11, DLF Ankur Vihar, Vill Sadullabad, Pargani Loni, Dist- Ghaziabad, UP. Area 700 Sq Ft Owner : Ram Darash Ram	23.10.2018 Rs.22.26 Lakh + Other Charges Applicable Deductions/ Repayments	19.02.2019 (Physical)	₹ 19,34,000.00 ₹ 1,93,400.00 ₹ 20,000.00
7.	I T Park Usmanpur Delhi	Mr. Hussain Ali Mobile: 9568431985	AJAY KUMAR MISHRA	Property Flat No. FF-3, LIG, First Floor, Front Side, Plot No. A-27, Ganga Vihar, Hadbast Gram Sadullahbad, Pargana - Loni, Tehsil and Dist- Ghaziabad, U.P., Area 37.16 Sq M Owner: Ajay Kumar Mishra	13.09.2023 Rs.8.57 Lakh + Other Charges Applicable Deductions/ Repayments	18.01.2025 (Physical)	₹ 9,90,000.00 ₹ 99,000.00 ₹ 10,000.00
8.	Vasundhra Ghaziabad	Mr. Anand Jaiswal Mobile: 8800013545	PUSHPENDER KUMAR	Second Floor Flat, SF-4, Four Story Building, Plot No B-5/1, DLF Ankur Vihar, Near Shiv Vatika Temple Loni Ghaziabad. Area 37.16 Sq Ft Owner: Pushpender Kumar	09.07.2018 Rs.14.09 Lakh + Other Charges Applicable Deductions/ Repayments	28.10.2020 (Physical)	₹ 9,00,000.00 ₹ 90,000.00 ₹ 10,000.00

E-AUCTION DATE: 08.07.2026, TIME: 12:00 NOON TO 04:00 PM WITH AUTO EXTENSION OF 10 MINUTES
Last Date & Time of Submission of EMD and Documents (Online) On or Before: 08.07.2026 Upto 03:30 PM.

Bidder will register on website: <https://BAANKNET.com> and upload KYC documents and after verification of KYC documents by the service provider, EMD to be deposited in BAANKNET EMD wallet through NEFT/RTGS/Transfer / Generation of challan from (<https://BAANKNET.com>). The auction will be conducted through common landing platform BAANKNET.com Portal (<https://BAANKNET.com>). E-auction will be held "As is where is", "As is what is" and "whatever there is" basis. (All other charges/dues to the property will be borne by the purchaser). For detailed terms and conditions please refer to the link provided in www.centralbank.bank.in Secured Creditor or auction platform (<https://BAANKNET.com>). Helpdesk: (+91) 8291220220, E-mail: support.BAANKNET@psballiance.com

STATUTORY 15 DAY'S SALE NOTICE UNDER RULE 8(6) & 9(1) OF THE SARFAESI ACT, 2002
Borrowers/Guarantors/ Mortgagors are hereby notified to pay the sum as mentioned above along with upto date interest and ancillary expenses before the date of e-auction, failing which the property will be auctioned/sold and balance dues, if any, will be recovered with interest and cost.

DATE: 18.06.2026
PLACE: DELHI
Authorised Officer,
CENTRAL BANK OF INDIA, RO Delhi (North), Delhi

 सेन्ट्रल बैंक ऑफ इंडिया Central Bank of India		Regional Office Delhi (North) 1398, First Floor, Chandni Chowk, Delhi-110006		E-AUCTION SALE NOTICE (Under SARFAESI Act 2002)			
1911 से आपके लिए "सेन्ट्रल" "CENTRAL" TO YOU SINCE 1911							
APPENDIX- IV-A [SEE PROVISO TO RULE 8(6) SALE NOTICE FOR SALE OF IMMOVABLE PROPERTIES							
E-Auction Sale Notice for sale of Immovable Assets under the Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 read with proviso to Rule 8(6) of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002.							
Notice is hereby given to the public in general and in particular to the borrower(s) and guarantor(s) that the below described immovable property mortgaged / charged to the Central Bank of India (secured creditor), the constructive/ physical Possession of which have been taken by the authorized officer of Central Bank of India(Secured creditors), will be sold on "As is where is", "As is what is" and "whatever there is" basis on date 24.07.2026 for recovery of dues to the Central Bank of India from below mention Borrower(s) and Guarantor(s). The Reserve Price and Earnest money deposit (EMD) is displayed against the details of respective properties.							
E-AUCTION SCHEDULED TO BE HELD ON 24.07.2026 (30 DAY'S NOTICE)							
S. No.	Name of Branch	Authorised Officer / B.M.	Name of the Account	Description of Property & Owner Name	Demand Notice Date & Amount Dues (In Rupees)	Date & Type of Possession	In Rupees Reserve Price EMD Bid Increase
1.	LRPG College Ghaziabad	Ms. Ekata Sharma Mobile: 8800013520	KUMAR GAURAV	Flat no FF-4, First Floor, Without Roof Rights Right hand Back Side S.L.F. Ved Vihar , Plot No. E-16,Village Sadullabad,Pargana,Tehsil Loni District Ghaziabad(UP) 201002. Area 37.16 Sq Mtr Owner: Kumar Gaurav	30.01.2025 Rs.13.71 Lakh + Other Charges Applicable Deductions/ Repayments	13.03.2026 (Physical)	₹ 14,00,000.00 ₹ 1,40,000.00 ₹ 15,000.00
2.	Patel Nagar Ghaziabad	Mr. Vinod Meena Mobile: 7976150263	SANJAY CHAUDHARY	All that Part And Parcel of Property in the name of Sanjay Chaudhary Bearing House No.875/C, 3rd Floor, Naya Khand-1, Indrapuram, Ghaziabad, Pin-201014. Area 209.95 Sq Ft Owner : Sanjay Choudhary	11.11.2024 Rs.13.08 Lakh + Other Charges Applicable Deductions/ Repayments	20.02.2026 (Physical)	₹ 13,23,000.00 ₹ 1,32,300.00 ₹ 15,000.00
3.	Sehani Ghaziabad	Mr. Abhay Mishra Mobile: 8588907378	M/S R S MARBLES	Part of Khasra No.2517, Pilkhwa, Hapur-245304, U.P. Area 334.45 Sq Mtr Owner : Balwant Kumar Sharma	17.05.2021 Rs.10.31 Lakh + Other Charges Applicable Deductions/ Repayments	31.01.2023 (Physical)	₹ 30,00,000.00 ₹ 3,00,000.00 ₹ 30,000.00
4.	Vasundhra Ghaziabad	Mr. Anand Jaiswal Mobile: 8800013545	SHIV SINGH	Flat No SF-2,Second Floor (With Roof Rights), Front Side, MIG, Plot No A-7/6, DLF Ankur Vihar, Loni Ghaziabad. Area 55.74 Sq Mtr Owner : Shiv Singh	04.02.2025 Rs.33.63 Lakh + Other Charges Applicable Deductions/ Repayments	16.01.2026 (Physical)	₹ 20,00,000.00 ₹ 2,00,000.00 ₹ 20,000.00
5.	Vasundhra Ghaziabad	Mr. Anand Jaiswal Mobile: 8800013545	Akash Sharma S/o Dinesh Sharma	Property- Flat No.SF-5, Second Floor (With Roof Rights), Back Side LIG, Plot No. A-7/6, DLF Ankur Vihar, Loni, Ghaziabad. Area 37.16 Sq Mtr Owner: Akash Sharma	12.09.2023 Rs.17.33 Lakh + Other Charges Applicable Deductions/ Repayments	16.01.2026 (Physical)	₹ 9,00,000.00 ₹ 90,000.00 ₹ 10,000.00
6.	Ghaziabad	Mr. Bhawani Deen Mobile: 9999467102	VIJAY RANJAN THOMAS	Built up Freehold Residential Property Bearing No. RZ-37 (Old No. 37) Second Floor, Back Side Portion, Without Roof/Terrace Rights, Built on Land. Area 50 Sq Yards or 41.80 Sq Mtr and Super Area 450 Sq ft , Total Plot Area 100 Sq Yard Out of Khasra No.35, Situated in the area of Village Bindapur, Delhi, Now Residential Colony Is Known as Subhash Park Uttam Nagar Extn II New Delhi - 110059. Area 50 Sq Yards Owner: Vijay Ranjan Thomas	11.11.2024 Rs.7.46 Lakh + Other Charges Applicable Deductions/ Repayments	29.04.2026 (Physical)	₹ 20,25,000.00 ₹ 2,02,500.00 ₹ 20,000.00
7.	Sadar Bazar Delhi	Mr. Sanjay Kumar Mobile: 8800013540	SUNIL KUMAR VERMA	Flat Bearing No.201, Second Floor Front Side,Property Bearing No.D-3/49-A portion of Plot No.4A, Out of Khasra No.69, Situated at Village Nasirpur, Colony Known as Mahavir Enclave New Delhi-110045. Area 405 Sq Ft Owner : Sunil Kumar Verma	16.07.2025 Rs.9.67 Lakh + Other Charges Applicable Deductions/ Repayments	30.05.2026 (Physical)	₹ 13,50,000.00 ₹ 1,35,000.00 ₹ 15,000.00

E-AUCTION DATE: 24.07.2026, TIME: 12:00 NOON TO 04:00 PM WITH AUTO EXTENSION OF 10 MINUTES
Last Date & Time of Submission of EMD and Documents (Online) On or Before: 24.07.2026 Upto 03:30 PM.

Bidder will register on website: <https://BAANKNET.com> and upload KYC documents and after verification of KYC documents by the service provider, EMD to be deposited in BAANKNET EMD wallet through NEFT/RTGS/Transfer / Generation of challan from (<https://BAANKNET.com>). The auction will be conducted through common landing platform BAANKNET.com Portal (<https://BAANKNET.com>). E-auction will be held "As is where is", "As is what is" and "whatever there is" basis. (All other charges/dues to the property will be borne by the purchaser). For detailed terms and conditions please refer to the link provided in www.centralbank.bank.in Secured Creditor or auction platform (<https://BAANKNET.com>). Helpdesk: (+91) 8291220220, E-mail: support.BAANKNET@psballiance.com

STATUTORY 30 DAY'S SALE NOTICE UNDER RULE 8(6) OF THE SARFAESI ACT, 2002
Borrowers/Guarantors/ Mortgagors are hereby notified to pay the sum as mentioned above along with upto date interest and ancillary expenses before the date of e-auction, failing which the property will be auctioned/sold and balance dues, if any, will be recovered with interest and cost.

DATE: 18.06.2026
PLACE: DELHI
Authorised Officer,
CENTRAL BANK OF INDIA, RO Delhi (North), Delhi



नरेन्द्र मोदी
प्रधानमंत्री

400 KM तक का
मेट्रो नेटवर्क

दिल्ली को मिली भारत की
पहली रिंग मेट्रो

12 साल

विश्वास के, विकास के, जनकल्याण के



रेखा गुप्ता
मुख्यमंत्री, दिल्ली सरकार



सत्यमेव जयते
दिल्ली सरकार

Ex-PM’s son duped of ₹7.8 cr by WhatsApp impersonator posing as him

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Former Rajya Sabha MP Naresh Gujral, son of former Prime Minister IK Gujral, was defrauded of ₹7.8 crore over four days.
The cyber criminals created a WhatsApp account using his profile picture and convinced an employee at his company to transfer funds across four separate transactions.
The scam unravelled when his daughter, alerted to the unusual demands, confirmed with her father that he had issued no such instructions.
The fraud unfolded between June 12 and June 16. An unknown number, carrying Gujral’s display picture, messaged a senior official in the financial division of his textile company with instructions to transfer money via Real-Time Gross Settlement to a specified bank account, citing urgent business reasons. The first transaction alone was for approximately ₹1.5 crore.
The official, who had been given financial access by Gujral, carried out the transfer without verifying the request through any other channel. Over the following days, three more transactions were requested and executed in the same manner. By the end of the four-day window, the company had transferred a total of ₹7.8 crore to accounts controlled by the fraudsters.
What makes the case notable is that the company’s bank flagged the unusual activity on its own. Alarmed by the size and frequency of the transactions, the bank contacted the company’s Chief Financial Officer to verify their legitimacy. The CFO, who appears to have also assumed the instructions originated from Gujral, authorised the transfers to proceed regardless. The bank’s intervention, though it did not stop the fraud at the time, would later prove significant in helping investigators trace where the money had gone.
The fraud came undone on June 16, when the employee who had been corresponding with the impersonator grew suspicious and reached out to Diksha, Gujral’s daughter. He told her about the money her father had supposedly been asking him to transfer.
Diksha, alarmed that her father had apparently developed an urgent need for such a large sum, asked him directly about the transactions.
Gujral told her he had never contacted the employee or requested any such transfers. The family immediately suspected fraud and approached the police.
An e-FIR was registered the same day.
A senior police officer confirmed that ₹4.28 crore of the ₹7.68 crore defrauded has already been marked as a lien or held in various banks, with efforts continuing to apprehend those responsible. Investigators said the money was first routed into four bank accounts in Maharashtra and Andhra Pradesh, with between ₹1 crore and ₹2 crore deposited in each. From there, the funds were dispersed across roughly 30 to 40 accounts and then moved through additional mule accounts in an apparent attempt to obscure the trail.
The case was taken up by the specialised Intelligence Fusion and Strategic Operations unit of Delhi Police, which tracked the transferred funds and found, unusually, that a significant portion of the money was still sitting in the banking system rather than having been cashed out or converted into cryptocurrency, the typical pattern in such frauds. This allowed ₹4 crore to be traced and frozen relatively quickly.
Gujral’s case is the latest in a line of high-profile cyber frauds targeting senior Indian industrialists and public figures. In September 2024, SP Oswal, the Padma Bhushan-winning chairman of the Vardhman Group, was duped of ₹7 crore by fraudsters who impersonated CBI officers, claiming his Aadhaar had been misused in a case linked to fake passports.
The fraudsters went as far as staging a fake virtual courtroom over video call, with one impersonating Chief Justice DY Chandrachud to issue an order against Oswal, before sending him a forged arrest warrant bearing the Enforcement Directorate’s name and seal over WhatsApp, placing the 82-year-old industrialist under what the gang called digital arrest for two days.
Gujral (78), trained as a chartered accountant before building a career in textiles and apparel manufacturing. He served as a Rajya Sabha MP from Punjab between 2007 and 2022 and remains a senior leader of the Shiromani Akali Dal. His father, IK Gujral, served as India’s Prime Minister for eleven months between April 1997 and March 1998.

NEET retest: Cooling zones set up for parents waiting outside exam centres

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

In a first, parents waiting outside NEET retest centres in Delhi on Sunday will have access to dedicated “cooling zones” with seating, drinking water, ORS, shikanji and first-aid facilities as many of whom spend several hours outside centres while candidates take the test.
The arrangements will be made at all 97 centres in the capital, where thousands of candidates are expected to appear for the medical entrance examination on June 21. The city Government has already announced free travel in DTC buses on the exam day. The announcement comes amid hot weather conditions in the national capital and follows concerns over the lack of waiting facilities for parents accompanying students to examination centres.
According to a press statement issued by the chief ministers’ office, Delhi Government will set up 97 ‘cooling zones’ and offer lemonade and other facilities to the parents of the NEET examinees outside the examination centres across the city. According to official figures, 69 of Delhi’s 97 NEET centres are located in Government schools, while 28 are in Kendriya Vidyalayas.
The Government said district administrations have been directed to set up waiting areas near examination venues for parents and guardians, many of whom spend several hours outside centres while candidates take the test.
Chief Minister Rekha Gupta said many parents are often left waiting outdoors for long periods during major examinations.
“Every year, millions of families arrive at examination centres carrying dreams for their children’s future. During the examination, candidates remain inside while parents wait outside for several hours. Yet the anxiety, heat, discomfort and inconvenience faced by parents often go unnoticed,” she said. She added that parents and family members have often been seen waiting under trees, in parks or around nearby markets during examination hours, particularly during peak summer conditions.
The cooling zones will have comfortable seating and provide ORS drinks, drinking water and lemonade to the parents while they rest and wait there. First aid and tea will also be available at the centres, according to the statement.
The chief minister noted that a total of 97 NEET examination centres have been set up in Delhi, including 69 in Government schools and 28 in Kendriya Vidyalayas.
The Delhi Government is already running 85 cooling zones where coolers, drinking water and other facilities are provided to people seeking shelter from summer heat.
“The anxiety, heat, discomfort and inconvenience faced by parents often go unnoticed. Understanding this human aspect, the Delhi Government has decided to ensure that parents do not face inconvenience on the day of the examination,” the chief minister said.
Candidates appearing for the NEET-UG 2026 re-examination in Delhi on June 21 will be allowed to travel free of cost on DTC and Delhi Integrated Multi-Modal Transit System (DIMTS) cluster buses, according to an official circular. As per the circular issued on June 15, candidates appearing for the NEET-UG 2026 re-examination can avail free travel on all Delhi Transport Corporation (DTC) and cluster buses throughout the day on June 21 by producing a valid admit card.
The concession will be available for both onward and return journeys, it said.
The circular directed depot managers to ensure that drivers and conductors are adequately informed about the arrangement and that no eligible candidate is denied the benefit under any circumstances.
Regional managers have also been asked to sensitise checking staff and terminal supervisors regarding the directions and ensure that complaints or queries from candidates are addressed promptly, it read.

EV policy 2.0 likely to be placed before Cabinet next week for approval

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi electric vehicle (EV) policy 2.0 is likely to be placed before the Cabinet headed by Chief Minister Rekha Gupta for approval next week, officials said on Thursday.
The draft of the new policy was placed in the public domain in April for stakeholders’ feedback. Incentivising hybrid vehicles under the policy is a sticky issue which is yet to be finalised by the authorities, a senior Government officer said.
Hybrid vehicles are powered by a conventional internal combustion engine and one or more electric motors, which use energy stored in batteries. The battery is self-charging, and it gets power from the combustion engine and regenerative braking, a process that captures energy generated during braking. The existing Delhi EV policy was extended up to June 30. “The policy is likely to be extended further, and so the approval of the new EV Policy 2.0 is imperative,” the officer added.

70-year Ambassador Hotel ownership row reaches HC; owners challenge eviction notice

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A nearly seven-decade-old ownership dispute involving Delhi’s iconic Ambassador Hotel has now reached the Delhi High Court, with the hotel owners challenging an eviction notice issued by the Central Government under the Public Premises (Eviction of Unauthorised Occupants) Act, 1971.
Sir Sobha Singh & Sons Private Limited, which owns the hotel, has challenged the June 9, 2026, decision of the appellate court that overturned a 2009 trial court decree, which had upheld the company’s claim over the property. According to the company, the Land and Development Officer (L&DO) issued an eviction notice on June 11, just two days after the appellate court ruling.
Justice Tejas Karia heard the matter on June 17 and admitted the appeal against the appellate court order.
Senior Advocate Sandeep Sethi appeared for the company and argued that there is an imminent threat of eviction in view of the notice issued by the Government. He also asked the Court for a stay on the notice.
Central Government Standing Counsel (CGSC) Ashish Dixit appeared for the Government and argued that the notice under the PP Act is independent of the judgment of the appellate court and deals only with the alleged unauthorised occupation. The matter will be heard next on July 23.
The dispute concerns the northern block of Suján Singh Park, next to Khan Market in Delhi. The Ambassador Hotel and some flats were developed by the appellant company on two plots of land, around 7.58 acres each, allotted by the Government of India in 1943. According to the company, under a 1945 agreement to lease, the Government promised a perpetual lease upon completion.

Husband held for allegedly stabbing wife to death

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Police arrested a man from Mumbai for allegedly murdering his wife in Delhi’s Gandhi Nagar area, officials said on Thursday. Khalid Navi, a Chanderpur resident from Kailash Nagar, was arrested on June 16 after a three-day interstate manhunt following the alleged murder of his wife, Rukhsar, who was around 30 years old.
According to police, they received information regarding the murder at the Gandhi Nagar police station on June 13. A police team rushed to the spot and found the victim dead. Forensic experts and the Crime Team examined the crime scene and recovered a blood-stained knife suspected to be the murder weapon. Police registered a case of murder under relevant sections of the BNS and initiated an investigation.
During the probe, investigators recorded statements from family members and witnesses and examined CCTV footage from the area, which allegedly showed the husband fleeing shortly after the crime.
Investigators relied on human intelligence and field enquiries. Teams were dispatched to multiple locations, including Badaun in Uttar Pradesh, Hubballi in Karnataka, Mumbai and Goa, while searches continued in Delhi. After sustained efforts and coordination with police units across states, investigators developed information that the accused was likely to contact his brother. Acting on the lead, they tracked him down and arrested him in Mumbai while he was allegedly attempting to conceal his identity.
“Despite the accused leaving almost no digital footprint, our teams relentlessly pursued all available leads across multiple states. Through extensive field verification, human intelligence and interstate coordination, the accused was apprehended within three days of the crime,” said Ajit Kumar Singla, Joint Commissioner of Police, Eastern Range.



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IN FOCUS



People take part in Kafil-e-Husaini procession on the second day of Muharram, in Lucknow, Thursday

PTI

Delhi University climbs in QS Global Rankings

Pioneer news service n New Delhi

The University of Delhi has improved its position in the QS World University Rankings 2027. The university has moved up six places to secure the 322nd rank globally, reinforcing its status as one of India's leading higher education institutions.

The latest rankings place Delhi University at 322, compared to 328 in the 2026 edition. The university has also retained its position as the top-ranked Indian university and remains seventh overall among all higher education institutions in the country.

According to the QS World University Rankings 2027, a total of 8,808 institutions worldwide were assessed, while 1,504 universities from 106 countries and territories secured places in the final rankings. Among the 52 Indian institutions featured, Delhi University continued



Vice Chancellor of Delhi University Professor Yogesh Singh (Right)

to strengthen its standing at both the national and international levels.

The university's overall score improved from 42.6 in the previous edition to 43.8 this year, reflecting progress across several performance indicators.

Vice-Chancellor Prof. Yogesh Singh said the improvement in rankings was the result of the collec-

tive efforts of faculty members, students, researchers, staff, alumni, and other stakeholders.

He said the university's continued rise in global rankings reflects the strength of its academic ecosystem and its commitment to excellence in teaching, research, innovation, sustainability, and social engagement.

One of the most significant



gains was recorded in the Citations per Faculty indicator, where Delhi University improved from 403rd position to 318th globally, a jump of 85 places.

The improvement reflects increasing visibility, quality, and impact of research produced by the institution.

The university also registered notable progress in sustainability. Its ranking in

this category improved from 297 to 240, gaining 57 places. The indicator measures institutional efforts related to environmental responsibility and social impact. Delhi University also improved its Employer Reputation ranking from 319 to 304, rising 15 places. The performance highlights growing recognition of its graduates among employers across different sectors and regions.

Among Indian institutions, the university recorded strong performances in several key categories. It ranked second in Employment Outcomes, reflecting the success of graduates in securing professional opportunities. The institution also climbed to fourth place nationally in Sustainability, improving from sixth position in the previous rankings. It secured fourth position among Indian institutions in the

International Research Network category, which evaluates global research collaborations and partnerships.

Delhi University retained its sixth position nationally in Academic Reputation, one of the most closely watched indicators in the QS rankings. The metric is based on the views of academics worldwide regarding the quality of teaching and research at institutions.

The latest rankings underscore Delhi University's growing international presence and its ability to compete with leading institutions globally.

The improvement also highlights the university's efforts to strengthen research output, sustainability initiatives, employability outcomes, and international academic engagement while maintaining its position among India's top universities.

Delhi police bust interstate child trafficking racket, 5 infants up for sale rescued

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

■ New Delhi

Delhi Police busted a major inter-state child trafficking syndicate across Delhi, Haryana, Rajasthan, Madhya Pradesh and Gujarat, arresting 13 people and rescuing five infants allegedly being sold to childless couples for lakhs of rupees.

The racket came to light on June 5 when a team from the Central District's Operations Unit conducted a decoy oper-

ation near RK Ashram Metro Station in Paharganj. Police apprehended three accused, including two women and a man, while they were allegedly attempting to sell a newborn baby boy, aged around four to five days, to decoy customers arranged by the police.

The infant was rescued safely, and the ₹20,000 paid as token money during the operation was recovered. A case was subsequently registered at Paharganj police

station under provisions of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita and the Juvenile Justice Act. According to investigators, sustained interrogation and technical surveillance exposed a well-organised trafficking network with suppliers, mediators, transporters, facilitators and buyers across multiple states. The syndicate allegedly procured infants from vulnerable families before transporting them to Delhi for illegal transfer.



Police said the trafficked children were sold to childless couples after fabricated

medical and birth-related documents were created to falsely establish legal parent-

age. Investigators found that infants were purchased for several lakhs of rupees.

A key breakthrough in the investigation was the arrest of a woman doctor who owns Heera Multi Speciality Hospital in Begampur. She was arrested for trafficking infants at the hospital, identifying prospective buyers among couples seeking fertility treatment and arranging forged medical and birth records to legitimise the transfers. Gedly acted as a

mediator in sourcing infants. Another accused worked as a driver and transporter for the syndicate.

Further investigation led police to the alleged kingpin supplier, identified as Sayabbhai Ghamar alias Kalia, who was traced and arrested from Gujarat on June 17 after technical surveillance and a prolonged chase. Police said he sourced newborns from different parts of Rajasthan and Gujarat and supplied them to the network.

During the investigation, police rescued four additional infants from Panipat in Haryana and Gwalior in Madhya Pradesh. In total, five infants, including four tribal babies and one child from Delhi, have been rescued and produced before the Child Welfare Committee for care and rehabilitation.

DCP (Central) Rohit Rajbir Singh said the operation had exposed a deeply entrenched trafficking network operating across several states.

Trump signs Iran truce in Versailles

In a major concession, Washington has agreed to issue waivers allowing Iran to resume oil exports without immediate sanctions restrictions. The move could significantly boost Iran's economy, which earned more than \$46 billion from oil exports in 2024 despite existing sanctions.

The accord further opens the possibility of broader sanctions relief, including the eventual lifting of US and United Nations sanctions linked to Iran's weapons programmes and human rights record. However, officials indicated that such measures would depend on progress during the forthcoming nuclear negotiations.

In return, Iran has agreed to dilute portions of its stockpile of highly enriched uranium and resume talks over the future of its nuclear programme. The Islamic Republic continues to maintain that its nuclear activities are exclusively peaceful. The agreement also includes provisions affirming Lebanon's territorial integrity amid continuing tensions involving Israel and the Hezbollah militant group. However, conflicting interpretations of this clause have already emerged. Iran insists that Israel must withdraw from occupied Lebanese territory, while Israeli leaders have rejected any such obligation.

Trump described the accord as "very strong" but suggested that military action could resume if negotiations fail.

"It's a memorandum of understanding, and if I don't like it, we'll go back to shooting at them, dropping bombs," the President told reporters.

The interim agreement represents a notable shift from Trump's earlier stance toward Iran. During his first term, Trump withdrew the United States from the 2015 Iran nuclear agreement, famously describing it as the "worst deal ever."

Analysts note that the new arrangement appears to grant Iran broader economic benefits than those available under the 2015 accord, particularly through the early relaxation of oil sanctions and the prospect of extensive future sanctions relief.

The deal is also expected to face political scrutiny in Washington, where critics argue that granting oil waivers at the outset weakens a key source of American leverage. In Israel, the agreement is likely to intensify pressure on Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu, who has faced growing criticism over the conduct and outcomes of the conflict.

Another significant aspect of the accord involves a proposed international reconstruction effort for Iran. Officials familiar with the negotiations indicated that Gulf Arab states could potentially invest up to \$300 billion in rebuilding damaged infrastructure, although such commitments would depend on future political and security developments.

For global markets, however, the reopening of the Strait of Hormuz is likely to be the most immediate and consequential outcome. The restoration of normal shipping traffic is expected to ease energy supply concerns and help stabilise oil prices after months of disruption.

With negotiations now entering a critical 60-day phase, the durability of the agreement will depend on whether Washington and Tehran can bridge longstanding differences over Iran's nuclear ambitions, regional influence and future sanctions relief.

PM Modi pitches India's inclusive AI vision...

"This agreement will expand our trade and investment, and it will open up many pathways for the exchange of talent, technology and tourism," he said.

Highlighting the growing technological partnership between India and France, PM Modi said the launch of the India-France Year of Innovation has brought the innovation ecosys-

tems of India and Europe closer together.

"From Bharat Innovates held a few days ago in Nice to VivaTech in Paris today, our start-ups are forging many new partnerships," he remarked.

Drawing parallels with his previous address at VivaTech in 2021 during the COVID-19 pandemic, the Prime Minister underscored the importance of innovation in navigating global challenges.

"In 2021, when I addressed VivaTech, the world was facing the disruption of COVID-19. Today, the world is experiencing disruptions of other kinds. I reiterate the message I shared then: where convention fails, innovation can help," PM Modi said.

The Prime Minister highlighted India's success in building digital public infrastructure, particularly the Unified Payments Interface (UPI), which now powers a significant share of global real-time digital transactions.

"Because of UPI, half the world's real-time digital transactions happen in India today. You can now use UPI in France too, at the Eiffel Tower and Paris Airport," he noted.

PM Modi also cited flagship initiatives such as Digi-Locker, the PM Gati Shakti platform, and the SVAMITVA scheme as examples of technology-driven governance and citizen empowerment.

Speaking about the role of emerging technologies in improving lives, the PM highlighted several Indian innovations ranging from AI-powered agricultural advisory systems to drone-based farming solutions and satellite-enabled fisheries management.

"Our technology solutions are delivering prosperity at the grassroots level," he said.

The PM also pointed to India's achievements in advanced technologies, including space exploration and nuclear energy.

"India became the first country to land near the Moon's south pole. Recently, India's prototype fast breeder reactor achieved criticality, bringing us closer to realizing our three-stage nuclear energy vision," he said.

With over 200,000 start-ups, India today hosts one of the world's largest and fastest-growing innovation ecosystems. PM Modi invited global investors and technology leaders to explore the India Pavilion at VivaTech, which features more than 80 Indian deep-tech companies and start-ups.

"You will see innovations ranging from the world's first single-piece 3D-printed rocket engine and advanced genetic-engineering therapies to AI solutions that detect cancer, improve cyber security, autonomous robots, smart cities and mobility solutions," he said.

Emphasising India's approach to AI, PM Modi called for technology that is accessible, inclusive, and beneficial for humanity.

"Technology can lead to progress only when it is democratized. India believes that in this era of disruption, technology must deliver for all. For India, AI means 'All Inclusive'," the PM stated. Reaffirming India's commitment to fostering innovation and entrepreneurship, Modi highlighted ongoing efforts to simplify regulations, improve ease of doing business, and support private enterprise through targeted incentives and affordable digital infrastructure.

"Our approach is clear. Government will enable and industry will innovate. Start-ups will disrupt and global partners will scale with us. Together, we will move faster than ever," he said. Calling upon global innovators and investors to deepen engagement with India, the PM concluded his address with a message of partnership and shared progress.

"Work with India and deliver for all," PM Modi said.

Following the keynote address, PM Modi and President Macron interacted with Indian start-ups and innovators showcasing frontier technologies and practical solutions in healthcare,

FROM PAGE - 1

sustainability, mobility, AI, and advanced computing.

India's participation at VivaTech 2026 is expected to further strengthen collaboration between Indian and French technology ecosystems, particularly as the two countries celebrate the India-France Year of Innovation.

Eknath Shinde scores big in Shiv Sena (UBT) coup

He also held the Supreme Court and the Election Commission responsible for the prevailing political situation in the country.

On Wednesday, a local Shiv Sena (UBT) leader in Washim had warned Sanjay Deshmukh that he would not be allowed to return to the constituency and his car would be set on fire if he switched loyalties without resigning as an MP first. Party workers in Dharashiv said that cow dung would be smeared on the faces of those who leave the party and they would not be allowed to move freely in the constituency.

Raut too warned the rebel MPs on Wednesday. "The traitors will not be able to go home or to their constituencies. They will be taught a proper lesson. They will need the help of the Army to reach home, they will need the Indian Air Force for protection," he said.

Indian funds dip in Swiss banks

These are official figures reported by banks to the Swiss National Bank (SNB) and do not indicate the quantum of the much-debated alleged black money held by Indians in Switzerland. These figures also do not include the money that Indians, NRIs or others might have in Swiss banks in the names of third-country entities.

The total amount of CHF 3,250.5 million, described by the SNB as 'total liabilities' of Swiss banks or 'amounts due to' their Indian clients at the end of 2025, included CHF 524 million in customer deposits, CHF 2.6 billion held via other banks, CHF 18.6 million (down 55 per cent from CHF 41 million) through fiduciaries or trusts, and CHF 105.7 million as 'other amounts' due to customers in form of bonds, securities and various other financial instruments (down from CHF 135 million).

The total amount stood at a record high of nearly 6.5 billion Swiss francs in 2006, after which it has been mostly on a downward path, except for a few years, including in 2011, 2013, 2017, 2020, 2021, 2022, 2023 and 2024, as per SNB data.

According to the SNB, its data for 'total liabilities' of Swiss banks towards Indian clients takes into account all types of funds of Indian customers at Swiss banks, including deposits from individuals, banks and enterprises. This includes data for branches of Swiss banks in India, as well as non-deposit liabilities.

On the other hand, the 'locational banking statistics' of the Bank for International Settlements (BIS), which have been described in the past by Indian and Swiss authorities as a more reliable measure for deposits by Indian individuals in Swiss banks, showed an increase of 20 per cent during 2025 in such funds to \$89.73 million (nearly Rs 780 crore).

It had risen by nearly 6 per cent in 2024, after dropping by 25 per cent in 2023, by 18 per cent in 2022 and by over 8 per cent in 2021. It rose by nearly 39 per cent in 2020.

It peaked at over \$2.3 billion (over ₹9,000 crore) at the end of 2007.

Swiss authorities have always maintained that assets held by Indian residents in Switzerland cannot be considered as 'black money' and they actively support India in its fight against tax fraud and evasion.

An automatic exchange of information in tax matters between Switzerland and India has been

in force since 2018. Under this framework, detailed financial information on all Indian residents having accounts with Swiss financial institutions since 2018 was provided for the first time to Indian tax authorities in September 2019, and this is being followed every year.

In addition to this, Switzerland has been actively sharing details about accounts of Indians suspected to have indulged in financial wrongdoings after the submission of prima facie evidence. Such an exchange of information has taken place in hundreds of cases so far.

The overall funds of foreign clients, including institutions, declined by nearly 8 per cent in 2025 to CHF 1.05 trillion.

In terms of assets, Indian clients accounted for CHF 1.5 billion at the end of 2024, down nearly 6 per cent from the previous year.

While the UK topped the charts for foreign clients' money in Swiss banks at CHF 192 billion, it was followed by the US (CHF 75 billion) at the second spot and France (CHF 63 billion) at the third place.

These three were followed in the top 10 by the West Indies, Germany, Hong Kong, Singapore, Luxembourg, UAE and the Netherlands.

India was placed at 46th place, up from 48th place at the end of 2024.

Pakistan also saw a dip to CHF 257 million (from CHF 272 million), while Bangladesh witnessed a sharp increase of 43 per cent to CHF 842 million. Just like in India, the issue of alleged black money in Swiss banks has been a political hot potato in the two neighbouring countries as well.

Bangladesh was at 81st place, while Pakistan was at 108th.

Cross-voting hands NDA RS win in Jharkhand

The ruling INDIA bloc, including the JMM and the Congress, has 56 members in the House.

In Meghalaya, Lalitluangkima secured 26 of the 36 votes polled, defeating Zothansangi Hmar of the Opposition Mizo National Front (MNF), who received all 10 votes cast by her party's legislators, according to Assembly Secretary and Returning Officer Zothansanga Ralte. Three legislators abstained from voting, including BJP MLAs K Beichhua and K Hrahmo, as well as lone Congress legislator C Ngunlianchunga. In the 40-member Mizoram Assembly, the ZPM holds 27 seats, followed by the MNF with 10, while the BJP and Congress have two and one legislators, respectively.

Doctor held for maid's murder in Capital

Deputy Commissioner of Police (South East) Hemant Tiwari said the motive behind the murder remains unclear and that investigators are examining all possible angles. Sources told *The Pioneer* that Gupta kept changing his statement. "The investigation is being conducted from all possible angles. We are also speaking to neighbours to determine whether there was any history of violence or disputes within the household," the officer said.

Police sources said Gupta's wife was not at home when the incident occurred, though his son was present.

CCTV footage from nearby buildings is being examined, while forensic teams have collected evidence from the crime scene.

The victim's family expressed shock over the incident and said they had never heard of any mistreatment by the employer's family. Sources noted that Meena often spoke positively about the Gupta household, saying they treated her well. They also claimed that she was paid adequately and had never complained about her employers.

"I don't know what exactly happened. She was

fine when she left. Someone called me and said she had died," Robin, Meena's son said.

The murder triggered anger among residents and domestic workers in the area. As news of the killing spread, a large crowd gathered outside the building. Several women broke down in tears and demanded strict action against the accused.

Police personnel remained deployed in the area to maintain law and order as forensic experts continued their examination of the scene. The body has been sent for postmortem, and further investigation is underway. According to the police, a case has been registered under relevant sections of the BNS.

Delhi HC questions restrictions on...

That Telegram's own disclosures further indicate that approximately 16,578 terrorist communities were banned during the first 15 days of June 2026 alone.

The channel records daily mass bans in June 2026 alone: 1,086 terrorist bots and channels on June 10, 130 on June 11, 1,843 on June 12, 575 on June 13, 30 on June 14, 603 on June 15, and 775 on June 16, taking the month's total to 17,353 entities in just 16 days. The extraordinarily high volume of such removals demonstrates the scale at which unlawful communities are created and continue to operate on the platform before being detected and removed. This is not a one-time abuse; it is continuous abuse by design. Even for terrorist content, which Telegram places its highest moderation priority on, the platform admits that banned bots and channels reappear every day despite prior measures being established in the NEET case," the Government said in its affidavit.

The affidavit states that Telegram's privacy and anonymity features have made it particularly attractive to criminal networks. According to the Centre, users can conceal identifiers such as phone numbers and Telegram IDs through privacy settings, making it difficult for investigators to establish the real identities behind accounts.

Citing a report of the Indian Cyber Crime Coordination Centre (I4C), the affidavit said that the app had become a preferred platform for cybercriminals, who use fake accounts, concealed identities, channels and groups to carry out unlawful activities, including financial frauds, malware distribution, data breaches and circulation of leaked papers. "Telegram is being exploited for illegal activities including drug trafficking, cybercrime, extremism, terrorism, child exploitation, and cyber scams and frauds, primarily due to privacy features," the affidavit said.

While reserving judgment, the judge asked counsel for both parties to file any written submissions by 7 pm. When the law officer spoke about the paper leak and the app's probable role in it, Justice Karia further said, "We are all alive to the situation (of paper leak). So many students were affected. But the aspect on the curb... can you ban the whole app? Let us focus on that. There is a power. That power can be exercised. To what extent can it be exercised? The question here is, can you block someone else's right to protect somebody else?" the bench asked.

The bench also asked: once the paper is leaked and goes viral, how can you deal with it in real time? And once a complaint is received, by the time action is taken, damage is done. "What real-time surveillance is there on your platform?" the bench asked before reserving the order.

On May 12, the National Testing Agency (NTA) had cancelled the National Eligibility-cum-Entrance Test (Undergraduate), or NEET-UG, held on May 3 for medical admissions amid allegations of paper leak. The matter is currently under investigation by the CBI.



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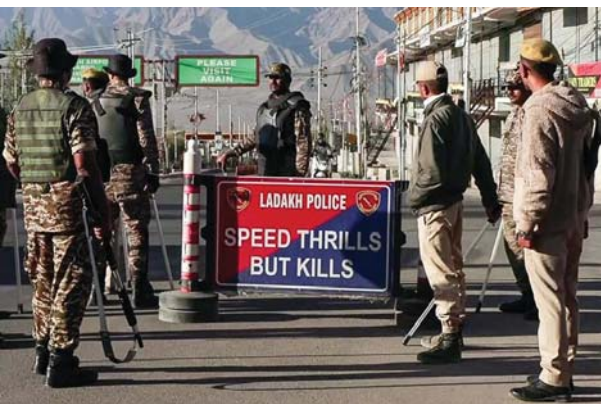


Leh Police bust conversion network, nab 8

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi/ Leh

Leh Police, following reliable intelligence, have broken up a suspected network involved in religious conversion activities in Ladakh and arrested eight people on Tuesday. This operation focused on stopping the recruitment of local youth and proselytisation efforts in the remote areas of Zaskar, Changthang, and the Aryan Valley. Police have filed FIR No. 126/2026 at Leh Police Station under the relevant sections of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS). Investigators say the accused rented a house in Skampari, Leh, which they

used as their main office for translating and sharing religious materials. Officials think this location was also used to coordinate conversion activities across Ladakh. During a search, police found laptops, digital devices, and other items linked to the group. These are now being reviewed to better understand the operation, including digital records of recruitment and content sharing. Investigators are also looking into possible financial transactions, especially any foreign funding. Authorities have not provided further details yet, but said they will track the network's reach and look for outside involve-



ment. This operation has drawn attention to activities in three culturally sensitive parts of Ladakh, including Zaskar, known for its remote

Buddhist monasteries and small population. Changthang is a high-altitude plateau where nomadic communities live. Aryan

Valley, along the Indus River, is home to the Brokpa people and is known for its unique culture. Police sources said the group was allegedly targeting local youth by recruiting and sharing religious literature translated into local languages. The Leh Police have launched a wide investigation to uncover the full network in Ladakh and identify everyone involved. Senior officers said they will take legal action based on the evidence found. "The Administration reiterates its commitment to safeguarding the peace, security, and cultural integrity of Ladakh," the police said in an official statement. Police have asked

the public not to spread rumours or unverified information about the case. Authorities said the investigation is fair and transparent, with a focus on keeping peace in this sensitive border area. The case has highlighted ongoing concerns about religious conversions in Ladakh, which has a large Buddhist population and a unique culture. Police have not released the names of those arrested or the religious group involved because of the sensitivity of the investigation. More updates will be shared as the forensic analysis of the seized devices and financial records continues.

Rahul launches campaign for education reform



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Congress leader Rahul Gandhi on Thursday launched a signature campaign to amplify issues related to the nation's education system, such as paper leaks and high fees, asserting that it is a platform for students to make demands directly to the government. In a post on X, Gandhi posted a link to the campaign where students can share ideas and sign a petition. "If you've suffered because of paper leaks, exam issues, or high fees, if this education system has shattered your dreams, if your family has invested a lifetime of savings in your education, then 'Chhatron Ki Goonj' is your voice," the Leader of Opposition in the Lok Sabha said in the post. Gandhi noted that this initiative goes beyond just a campaign; it is a platform for students to raise issues such as the need for affordable education, fair examinations, and dignified employment opportunities. "Join the movement: Click the link below. Fill

in your name and share your ideas. Sign the petition — that's it," Gandhi said, urging the youth to sign up for this movement. "More the signatures, louder the goonj!" he added. His appeal for participation in the campaign followed a day after he interacted with students at a convention in Kota, Rajasthan. During this interaction, he described India's education system as a "rejection system" rather than a selection system, claiming it places an excessive financial burden and causes significant stress to students and middle-class families. While addressing the gathering in Kota, known for its coaching centres, Gandhi remarked that the current education structure is "extremely stressful and unfair." "This is not good for the country. I want all of us to work together to ensure that no student in this country ever feels what this girl felt," he said at the "Chhatron ki Goonj" Maha Rally in Kota, where he interacted with students on various issues like paper leaks and unemployment.

US Ambassador calls on Amit Shah

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

US Ambassador to India Sergio Gor called on Union Home Minister Amit Shah on Thursday, and the two discussed strengthening cooperation in security, particularly in counter-terrorism and counter-narcotics. This comes a day after the meeting between Prime Minister Narendra Modi and US President Donald Trump at the G7 summit in Evian-les-Bains, France. In a social media post, Shah said, "Met US Ambassador to India, Mr Sergio Gor in New Delhi today. Had a detailed discussion on further strengthen-



Union Home Minister Amit Shah during a meeting with US Ambassador to India Sergio Gor in New Delhi

ing cooperation between India and the US in the area of security, particularly in counter-terrorism and counter-narcotics."

He said under the leadership of Prime Minister Modi, India is firmly committed to

advancing the India-US Comprehensive Global Strategic Partnership and ensuring that the people of both nations benefit from the bilateral relationship. Gor termed his meeting with Shah "excellent". "We had a fruitful discussion on enhancing collaboration to combat terrorism, shield our people from narcotics and illicit drugs, secure our borders, and jointly bring criminals to justice in both nations," he said in a social media post. In another post, Gor said, ""Back in New Delhi after a great trip to the G7 in France. Lots of positive outcomes between the United States and India!"

Rahul not acceptable to allies: BJP after RS win

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The BJP on Thursday said the Rajya Sabha seat result in Jharkhand shows that allies in the INDIA bloc have rejected Rahul Gandhi's leadership. The ruling party at the Centre also called Gandhi a "liability" for the INDIA bloc. Amid cross-voting, NDA-supported Independent candidate Parimal Nathwani on Thursday won one of the two Rajya Sabha seats in Jharkhand, defeating the Congress's Pranav Jha. Jharkhand Mukti Morcha (JMM) candidate Baidyanath Ram was elected to the other

seat. Nathwani polled 28 votes, while Jha bagged 20 votes. BJP spokesperson Shehzad Poonawalla alleged that the opposition alliance is plagued by infighting. "It is a loss for Rahul Gandhi. It is a loss for the INDIA alliance and a loss for the Congress. It shows that Rahul Gandhi is not a cool prime ministerial candidate. He is a "burden for the INDIA alliance," Poonawalla said in a video statement. "Once again, the INDIA alliance is in tatters and has demonstrated an uncanny ability to snatch defeat from the jaws of victory because of infighting," he said. Poonawalla claimed that



both Rajya Sabha seats in Jharkhand should have gone to the INDIA bloc, which did not happen because of cracks in the alliance. "It is evident that both seats in Jharkhand should have gone to the INDIA alliance. While the JMM won

its seat, Congress lost because the JMM, RJD and Left parties revolted against the Congress candidate," he said. The BJP spokesperson alleged that the loss of the second seat shows that Gandhi's leadership is not being accepted either by voters or by his allies. "He has lost 99 elections. We have seen voices of dissent within the Congress against him. Even his loyalists are leaving him," Poonawalla said. Referring to a recent INDIA bloc meeting, he claimed that several alliance partners had criticised Gandhi, the leader of Opposition in the Lok Sabha.

No sensitive examination-related information compromised, claims ICAI

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Chartered accountants' apex body ICAI on Thursday said no sensitive information related to its examination process has been compromised amid reports claiming that there was unauthorised access to the examination records. The statement from the Institute of Chartered Accountants of India (ICAI) also came on a day when it announced the final examination results. Out of the 87,497 candidates admitted for the final examinations held in May, a total of 7,931 candidates qualified as chartered accountants, as per the results announced on Thursday. The institute, set



up under an Act of Parliament, conducts final examinations twice a year. In a statement on Thursday, ICAI assured all stakeholders that no candidates' examination records, answer books, marks data, or any sensitive information related to the examination process have been compromised. Against the backdrop of reports in

social media alleging security breach in one of the institute's examination-related portal and unauthorised access to the examination records, the institute urged stakeholders not to give any credence to such false, baseless and mischievous campaign. The institute, which has nearly 12 lakh students, also said stringent action in accordance with law would be taken against persons spreading such rumours and false claims. It clarified that the "portal being referred to, namely examiners.icaiaexam.icaai.org, is a training portal used exclusively for examiner orientation and has nothing to do with exam-related records as claimed in these posts".

New BJP govt will end threat culture: Governor

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kolkata

Promising to dismantle the "threat culture" and corruption syndicates allegedly nurtured under the previous regime, West Bengal Governor RN Ravi on Thursday outlined the BJP government's governance roadmap, coupling a tough border and national security pitch with promises of industrial revival, welfare delivery and administrative transparency. Delivering the customary address on the opening day of the first budget session of the newly elected assembly, Ravi asserted that voters had delivered a decisive mandate for change after "one and a half decades" of fear and despair. "The people of West Bengal have given a clear mandate for a new government. They

have rejected the atmosphere of fear and frustration prevailing in the state for a long time," he said. The 36-minute address, which set the tone for the BJP government's first budget session since ending the TMC's 15-year rule, sought to present the Suvendu Adhikari administration as one focused on restoring law and order, curbing corruption and tightening border security. "The new government has launched a crackdown on anti-social elements who were given protection by the previous regime. The government will also do away with the threat culture and corruption syndicates," Ravi said. Drawing one of the sharpest political contrasts with the previous dispensation, the governor accused the former regime of allow-



ing criminal syndicates, extortion rackets, illegal coal and sand mining networks, trafficking and crimes against women and children to flourish. "My government will take all necessary measures to restore the rule of law and people's trust in the state's institutions," he said. A key theme running through the address was

illegal infiltration, an issue repeatedly highlighted by BJP leaders, including Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Union Home Minister Amit Shah, during the assembly election campaign. Ravi expressed concern over what he described as demographic changes in border districts caused by unchecked infiltration over

the years. "The influx of illegal infiltrators along the long, porous international border over the last decades has severely impacted the demographic balance in our state. The fulfillment of needs of the rightful citizens has been compromised because of presence of large number of illegal infiltrators here with active indulgence of some vested interest groups within the state itself," he said. Without naming the previous government, he alleged that sections within the state had facilitated the process, and said the new administration was committed to identifying and deporting illegal foreigners. "My government is committed to stopping illegal infiltration and taking strict action to identify and deport illegal foreigners," he said.

Nadda reviews dengue, malaria preparedness ahead of monsoon season

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Union Health Minister JP Nadda on Thursday reviewed the current situation regarding dengue and malaria across the country, emphasising the need for heightened vigilance to prevent and control the mosquito-borne diseases. During a high-level review meeting with senior officials from the ministry, Nadda stressed the importance of early preparedness and a proactive public health response to manage dengue and malaria during the upcoming monsoon and post-monsoon months. He highlighted that coordinated efforts among the central government, state and Union Territory (UT) administrations, local authorities, and

healthcare institutions are essential to minimise the disease burden and ensure timely responses to emerging public health challenges. Nadda directed all states to strengthen their surveillance systems for the early detection of cases and outbreaks. He underscored the importance of prompt reporting, active monitoring, and rapid response mechanisms to contain the spread of infections. Nadda instructed hospitals and healthcare facilities across the country to remain fully prepared and ensure the adequate availability of medicines, diagnostic facilities, blood components, hospital beds and trained healthcare personnel. He emphasised that patient care services should remain uninterrupted and that



healthcare institutions must be equipped to effectively manage any increase in patient load. Nadda also highlighted the importance of strict adherence to standard treatment guidelines and clinical management protocols for dengue and malaria. He

directed officials to ensure that all healthcare facilities are sensitised regarding the latest protocols for diagnosis, treatment and case management to improve patient outcomes and reduce complications. Emphasising the critical role of preventive measures, Nadda called for intensified

vector control activities, including source reduction, elimination of mosquito breeding sites, fogging and other public health interventions in vulnerable areas. He urged states and local bodies to undertake sustained preventive actions in coordination with communi-

ty stakeholders. Additionally, Nadda stressed the need to enhance public awareness regarding preventive measures against mosquito-borne diseases. He called for widespread Information, Education and Communication (IEC) campaigns to educate citizens on maintaining cleanliness, preventing water stagnation, using personal protective measures and seeking timely medical attention in case of symptoms. He also encouraged the active participation of Resident Welfare Associations, Panchayati Raj Institutions, educational institutions, and community organisations in maintaining mosquito-free environments. Nadda reiterated that awareness, early diagnosis, timely treatment and community

participation remain the key pillars in the fight against dengue and malaria. He assured that the Ministry of Health and Family Welfare is closely monitoring the situation and extending all necessary support to states and Union Territories for strengthening preparedness and response measures. The review assessed the current epidemiological situation, disease surveillance mechanisms, preparedness of health facilities, availability of diagnostics and drugs, vector control measures, and inter-sectoral coordination for prevention and management of dengue and malaria. Furthermore, Nadda assessed the availability of diagnostic kits, medicines, laboratory infrastructure, trained manpower and finan-

cial resources across states and Union Territories for the upcoming transmission season. He directed officials to develop district-specific strategies and micro-plans, particularly for endemic and high-risk areas, and emphasised that effective surveillance, early diagnosis and prompt treatment are critical for reducing disease burden. States and Union Territories have been advised to undertake regular reviews at district and municipal levels, intensify source reduction and vector control activities, and strengthen public awareness campaigns. Special emphasis has been laid on hotspot mapping, anti-larval measures, rapid response mechanisms and enhanced monitoring during the high-transmission season.

States Focus



PRESIDENT OFFERS PRAYERS AT OMKARESHWAR TEMPLE

President Droupadi Murmu on Thursday offered prayers at the Omkareshwar Jyotirlinga temple in Madhya Pradesh's Khandwa district. Murmu spent about 10 minutes at the temple situated on the banks of the Narmada river, officials said. Madhya Pradesh Governor Mangubhai Patel accompanied her during the visit. Later, Murmu also offered prayers at the Mamleshwar temple, another prominent temple dedicated to Lord Shiva in the pilgrimage town. Before entering the sanctum sanctorum of the Mamleshwar temple, the President offered 'bel' leaves at the statue of Nandi, the officials said. The temple priests conducted the ritual worship and 'abhishek' (sacred bathing) of Lord Shiva as per the Vedic traditions amid chanting of hymns. According to Hindu religious beliefs, a pilgrimage to Omkareshwar is considered complete only after paying obeisance at the Mamleshwar temple. While the Omkareshwar temple is situated on one bank of the Narmada river, the Mamleshwar temple stands on the other side of the riverbank.



NIA CHARGESHEETS KEY NAXAL OPERATIVE FOR INCITING MOB

The National Investigation Agency (NIA) on Thursday filed a chargesheet against a key Naxal operative for allegedly inciting a mob at a funeral of a deceased member of a proscribed Maoist outfit. Gade Innaiiah, alias Gade Inna Reddy, was named in the chargesheet filed before an NIA special court at Nampally, Hyderabad. NIA alleged that Gade, who was arrested in December 2025, had two months earlier made incriminating remarks at the funeral meeting of Katha Ramachandra Reddy, a deceased Central Committee member of CPI (Maoist). The probe agency in a statement said Gade incited a gathering of around 200 people at the funeral by urging them to actively promote the ideology of CPI (Maoist) and never let the revolution die. He also lambasted the erstwhile CPI (Maoist) cadres who surrendered their weapons before government agencies, it said. According to the NIA, Gade was closely associated with several senior cadres of CPI (Maoist) and used to meet them in the jungle areas of Chhattisgarh. He was found to be actively involved in propagating the terror outfit's ideology through a frontal organisation, 'Bharat Bachao', of which he was a co-founder, the NIA said.

Modi to transfer PM-KISAN funds to 9.44 crore farmers on June 20

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Prime Minister Narendra Modi will transfer the 23rd instalment under the PM-KISAN scheme, disbursing ₹18,880 crore directly to over 9.44 crore farmer beneficiaries across the country on June 20.

The transfer will take place during his visit to Hooghly district in West Bengal.

In West Bengal alone, more than 45.35 lakh farmers will receive instalments totalling approximately ₹907 crore, Agriculture Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan said.

With this, the cumulative disbursement under the scheme in the state will cross ₹15,055 crore, while the national total since the scheme's launch in 2019 will surpass ₹4.46 lakh crore, he said in a statement.

Chouhan said the funds would be routed through Direct Benefit Transfer (DBT), "strengthening the income security of small and marginal farmers."



Modi will also launch the Pradhan Mantri Fasal Bima Yojana (PMFBY) and the Restructured Weather-Based Crop Insurance Scheme (RWBCIS) in West Bengal, with a combined outlay of approximately ₹12,200 crore, he said in a statement.

The government aims to extend crop insurance coverage to about 1.10 crore farmers across 30 lakh

hectares during 2026-27, covering crops valued at roughly ₹28,140 crore.

Under the Digital Agriculture Mission, the Prime Minister will launch an Agri-Tech platform in the state, offering an integrated interface for fertiliser distribution, Kisan Credit Cards, DBT services, and MSP-based government procurement.

Modi will launch the

National Natural Farming Mission, under which 346 natural farming clusters spanning 17,300 hectares will be set up in West Bengal during 2026-27. The initiative is expected to benefit 43,250 farmers through bio-based inputs, training, and market linkages, supported by bio-resource centres and 'Krishi Sakhis'. He will also launch the Pradhan Mantri Dhan-Dhanya Krishi Yojana in the districts of Purulia, Darjeeling, Alipurduar, and Jhargram, targeting improved agricultural productivity, crop diversification, and post-harvest infrastructure, including storage and processing facilities.

Modi will inaugurate 49 road projects worth over ₹213 crore under PMGSY-III, covering more than 315 kilometres.

The roads are intended to improve rural connectivity, help farmers reach markets, and ease access to education and healthcare for residents in remote areas.

26,474 kms of rural roads to be constructed in FY 2026-27: Govt

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Central government has earmarked ₹18,907 crore for the construction of 26,474 kilometres of rural roads under the Pradhan Mantri Gram Sadak Yojana and other rural connectivity initiatives in the financial year 2026-27, the Rural Development Ministry said on Thursday.

This was highlighted during a comprehensive high-level review meeting chaired by Secretary of the Department of Rural Development, Rohit Kansal, to assess state-wise physical and financial progress under the Pradhan Mantri Gram Sadak Yojana (PMGSY) and the Road Connectivity Project for Left Wing Extremism-affected areas.

According to a statement issued by the ministry, Kansal reviewed state-wise targets and implementation status for 2026-27, with special emphasis on achieving saturation of rural connectivity in left-out areas.

A major focus of the review was the quality and long-term sustainability of rural roads. Kansal said strict adherence to quality standards and effective maintenance are essential to ensure reliable rural connectivity.

Recognising the strategic importance of road infrastructure in Left Wing Extremism-affected districts, the secre-



placed on the universal deployment of the e-MARG (Electronic Maintenance of Rural Roads under PMGSY) platform, enabling real-time monitoring of maintenance activities, performance assessment, and payment tracking. Wider adoption of the platform is expected to improve transparency, accountability and efficiency in rural road maintenance.

tary directed the states to closely coordinate with the implementing agencies and ensure the timely completion of works.

States were directed to expedite the completion of works in all remaining unconnected habitations under PMGSY-I and Pradhan Mantri Janjati Adivasi Nyaya Maha Abhiyan, with particular attention to the Particularly Vulnerable Tribal Group habitations.

Emphasising the need for universal all-weather roads, the secretary urged states to fast-track the preparation of detailed project reports, resolve execution bottlenecks and ensure the timely completion of pending connectivity projects.

States were urged to strengthen field-level inspections, enhance quality monitoring systems and ensure robust oversight throughout project execution.

At the meeting, emphasis was also

Centre may issue more ration cards after ineligible holders removed: Joshi

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Union Food Minister Pralhad Joshi on Thursday said there is scope for issuing nearly 3 crore more ration cards to eligible beneficiaries after some state governments removed 2.21 crore ineligible holders from PDS lists.

Addressing the launch of a smart warehousing system, Joshi said the deletions were carried out by state governments following their own criteria, not by the Centre. The food ministry had identified 8.51 crore ineligible beneficiaries, including names of deceased persons, income-tax payers and four-wheeler owners, and forwarded the list to states for action.

"Out of 8.51 crore, states have withdrawn 2.21 crore ration cards. We have not withdrawn," he said, adding that the exercise was made possible by digitisation of the public distribution system (PDS).

States have been permitted to add eligible beneficiaries, and "nearly 3 crore more ration cards can be issued to eligible people by various state governments," Joshi told reporters on the sidelines of the event.

He noted that deletions have not been uniform across the country: some states have completed the exercise while others are yet to identify ineligible beneficiaries.



"All put together, now there are 79 crore beneficiaries in the country," he said, stressing the Centre's objective is not to save but to ensure foodgrains reach the needy. The target for distributing free foodgrains under the Pradhan Mantri Garib Kalyan Yojana remains at 80 crore, he said.

The minister said PDS digitisation has led to 98.5 per cent of foodgrains distributed under PMGKY being authenticated through Aadhaar numbers and ePoS machines.

New technologies are being deployed across PDS operations, including smart warehouses and depots, and the ministry is working towards a fully digital distribution system.

Joshi also claimed that about 25 crore people have moved out of multidimensional poverty since Covid due to implementation of several schemes, including PMGKY, citing international forums such as the IMF and Niti Aayog. On the possibility of an increase in the food subsidy bill this year, he said the government "will be able to manage with the allocation budget".

Amarnath Yatra: 45 mountain rescue teams set for deployment on routes

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Srinagar

Jammu and Kashmir Director General of Police Nalin Prabhat on Thursday flagged off 45 mountain rescue teams for deployment along the twin routes for Amarnath Yatra.

The 45 teams — comprising Jammu and Kashmir Police, State and National Disaster Response Forces, Central Reserve Police Force, Sashastra Seema Bal and Border Security Force — will be deployed at 21 locations along the two routes to the sacred Amarnath cave shrine in the South Kashmir Himalayas.

"Like every year, our teams will be stationed there to assist pilgrims this year too. They will provide every kind of facility (to the devotees). And God forbid, if any disaster occurs, they will actively respond to it and tackle it," SDRF Director Imtiyaz Hussain Mir told reporters here. Mir said the annual Amarnath Yatra is a very sacred pilgrimage in the country.



"The overall role of Jammu and Kashmir Police in this is very important, along with other security forces. These mountain rescue teams are specially trained. Most of them have been deployed before as well. They provide all kinds of assistance, especially in emergencies, to pilgrims who come here from every corner of the country," he added.

Mir said extra effort was put in and equipment augmented for this year's deployment.

"We are trying to provide better facilities for the mountain rescue team so that they can offer better services to the pilgrims. We hope the yatra will be very successful. We will fulfil this duty and responsibility completely," he added.

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Sushri Shobha Karandlaje

Hon'ble Minister of State for Labour & Employment and Micro, Small & Medium Enterprises, Government of India

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Editor's
TAKE

Trump inks peace deal, world takes a deep breath

The Washington-Tehran agreement marks the first meaningful diplomatic breakthrough since the devastating US-Israeli strikes of February 28

History rarely arrives neatly. It comes instead in the form of a Truth Social post: "The Deal with the Islamic Republic of Iran is now complete. Congratulations to all!" The 14-point Memorandum of Understanding signed between Washington and Tehran, brokered by Pakistan in what is now called the Islamabad Declaration, is neither a triumph nor a treaty. It is a respite. And in a West Asia that has burned for nearly four months – since the US-Israeli strikes of February 28 that killed Supreme Leader Khamenei and shattered Iran's military architecture – even a respite deserves acknowledgment.

The agreement asserts that Iran can never develop a nuclear weapon and commits both sides to addressing Iran's existing enriched uranium stockpile, with the minimum methodology being down-blending on-site under IAEA supervision. Point 5 of the MOU commits Iran to arranging safe, toll-free passage of commercial vessels through the Strait of Hormuz for 60 days.

Point 6 pledges the United States, with regional partners, to develop a reconstruction and economic development fund of at least \$300 billion for Iran. Points 9 and 10 establish a status quo freeze – Iran pauses its nuclear programme, the US issues waivers for Iranian oil exports and banking transactions, and frozen Iranian assets are made available for use.

Critically, the framework sets a 60-day window for negotiations to resolve the fate of Iran's nuclear programme, enrichment levels, and highly enriched uranium stockpiles. Oil prices have already begun retreating from their \$100-plus wartime highs towards \$74-78 per barrel. Global inflation, supply chains, and energy-importing nations from India to Germany stand to benefit enormously if the Hormuz reopening holds. Markets the world over have celebrated the deal. The Dow hit a record high the day the deal was announced. Though not everyone was happy.

Israel's Prime Minister Netanyahu, in his first comments on the deal, acknowledged that he and Trump "do not always see eye to eye", while making clear Israel intends to continue its military occupation of Lebanon, Gaza and Syria. Israel's ambivalence is a live fault line under this peace.

A memorandum is not a monument. To make this peace durable, several things must follow: the 60-day nuclear negotiations must yield a verifiable, permanent enrichment framework with genuine IAEA teeth; the \$300 billion reconstruction pledge must materialise rather than remain a diplomatic abstraction; and crucially, Israel and Hezbollah must be brought formally into a comprehensive regional settlement – because both sides have continued sporadic strikes even after the April ceasefire, and the Lebanon front remains technically outside the MOU's binding framework. Peace, like all fragile things, requires more care after signing than before. The world has its respite. Now comes the harder work – to prolong it as long as possible.

The empire forgets, Iran remembers

As Iran returns to the global spotlight, its football team has become an unlikely vessel for national memory, resilience and a civilisation's refusal to forget



BHOPINDER SINGH

FIFA's 20th-ranked team, ie, Iran, is not amongst the frontrunners to win the 2026 Football World Cup. Yet it is amongst the most talked-about teams participating. Much like the nation in the midst of its war with the United States of America and Israel, it is built around a solid control framework, with a highly defensive ability to counterpunch and transition through its battle-hardened players. It can spring surprises when least expected.

Perhaps the most symbolically poignant image to come out of the tournament was the sight of Iranian footballers wearing "#168" lapel pins, a silent homage to the memory of 168 schoolgirls killed in the deadly missile airstrike by the United States of America on a school in Iran. It was a continuation of an effort to memorialise the conscience and wounds imagined by a hurt (but not defeated) people. Weeks earlier, Iranian footballers had movingly held up pink and purple school backpacks while their national anthem played in a warm-up game in Turkey. Even Team Melli's (Iranian National Football Team) anthem is a telling ode to perseverance, pride and fighting spirit, with the evocative lyrics "until the last breath"!

In Shi'a sensibility, symbolism and remembrance of suffering are fundamental because they keep alive the memory of Karbala and the moral struggle against injustice, wherein Karbala becomes the universal metaphor, as every age has its Husayn and its oppressors (in this case, the United States of America). The emotional power of grief, martyrdom and historical memory gives Shiite religious culture much of its distinctive character and resilience. Therefore, the emergence of a popular phrase, "Angels of Minab", serves to internalise and institutionalise the tragic loss in national character and conscience. But such profound religio-cultural nuance is not expected to cut ice with an insensitive ignoramus like the President of the United States of America, Donald Trump. In the deep recesses of Iranian-Shiite belief systems, never (ever) forgetting and preserving memory is viewed as a way of giving enduring meaning to loss.

When two conflicting nations contest, each carries a book of grievances where the first page is never the same. Very selectively and conveniently, the American imagination of the tensions starts with the Iranian Revolution in 1979 in order to begin where innocence is easiest to claim. For the Iranian



THE WORLD AT LARGE MAY SEE THE REOPENING OF THE STRAIT OF HORMUZ AND THE RESUMPTION OF FLIGHT ROUTES WHEN THE WAR FINALLY ENDS AND THE GUNS FALL SILENT, BUT HISTORICAL WOUNDS WILL FESTER AND ENDURE UNTIL THEY ARE ACKNOWLEDGED

The writer is a former Lieutenant Governor of the Andaman and Nicobar Islands and Puducherry, and a military veteran

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family of the Holy Prophet after Karbala, etc. In many ways, these footballers seek to immortalise the sacred memory of 168 little lives by identifying emotionally with their worldly absence as part of their "martyrological" worldview.

For the overwhelming Shia majority in Iran, memory (Dhikr) is a moral duty – the lesson of Karbala is: "never forget what happened when people looked away". That is exactly the message these Iranian footballers bring to television screens as they beseech the fleeting humanity in most, who would rather "forget the past and move on", as is the wont of modern times. However, for the Iranian Milli, the players may wear the jersey. The 168 little schoolgirls wear the memory. Together, they walk onto the pitch and shame a boorish Empire.

Following the much-banded peace talks, a semblance of normalcy may return before trust returns. Nations can sign peace treaties, but in a civilisational land like Iran, memories are respected, nurtured and carried for generations. The world at large may see the reopening of the Strait of Hormuz and the resumption of flight routes when the war finally ends and the guns fall silent, but historical wounds will fester and endure until they are acknowledged. History is equally instructive that a small-spirited and uncouth leader like Donald Trump will never admit the wrong and injury inflicted upon Iranian pride. Thankfully, the Iranian football team is seemingly cut from a better cloth, and they will never forget.

The Pioneer
SINCE 1865

The silent burden of modern educators

comes. Coordinators focus on curriculum implementation, assessment schedules and regulatory compliance, while authorities expect schools to follow prescribed guidelines and policies. Society, in turn, places the responsibility on teachers to nurture responsible and value-driven citizens. Amid all these expectations, learners themselves seek an education that is engaging, personalised, comfortable and meaningful. Amidst all these expectations is a teacher striving to balance various demands while staying effective, motivated and emotionally present.

Discussions about education often focus on students, infrastructure, technology and curriculum reforms. Yet one vital question remains unanswered: Who is looking after the teachers? A teacher's work does not end with the final school bell. Lesson planning, assessments, reports, meetings and parent communication continue long after classroom hours. While technology was meant to simplify teaching, it has often added to the workload, leaving less time for meaningful teaching and student interaction.

The situation becomes even more complex because every stakeholder in the school system operates under pressure. School heads answer to managements, governing bodies, regulatory authorities and parents. Coordinators and department heads are expected to ensure curriculum delivery, maintain academic stan-

dards, monitor assessments, support teachers, address parent concerns and translate institutional policies into classroom practice. Yet educational leadership cannot be limited to monitoring deadlines, reports and performance data. Effective leaders are not merely supervisors; they are facilitators, mentors and advocates for their teachers. The strongest schools are not only those with impressive infrastructure or high examination results, but those where leaders understand that teacher well-being directly affects student learning. Teachers who feel trusted, supported and valued are more likely to teach with confidence, creativity and commitment.

Society expects teachers to build resilience, inspire creativity and shape future leaders, yet often overlooks their own well-being. Burdened by growing administrative demands, many educators receive limited support for their professional and emotional growth.

A school's success should be measured not only by results, but also by teacher satisfaction, retention and workplace well-being. The future of education depends on recognising a simple truth: teachers are not machines designed to absorb unlimited pressure. If students are to flourish, we must first support those who stand at the front of the classroom.

The Pioneer
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The writer is an educator and a councillor

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Misplaced focus on Telegram

The government's response to the NEET question paper leak by suspending or restricting Telegram services raises serious concerns. While preventing the spread of leaked material is important, targeting a communication platform without addressing the root cause of the problem appears both unfair and ineffective. Millions use Telegram for legitimate educational, professional and personal purposes. Penalising all users for the actions of a few does not serve the interests of justice. The real focus of the investigation should be on identifying how the question paper was leaked in the first place. Authorities must examine who was involved in setting the paper, what security protocols were followed during its preparation, printing, storage and transportation, and where the breach occurred. Every stage of the process should be thoroughly scrutinised.

It is equally important to determine whether negligence, corruption or deliberate misconduct was involved. Unless these questions are answered, the true culprits may escape accountability and similar incidents could recur. Technology platforms are merely tools. Blaming Telegram risks diverting attention from systemic failures. Only a thorough investigation and stronger safeguards can restore public confidence in the examination system.

AP THIRUVADI | CHENNAI

Fuel pricing failures deepen energy crisis

India's domestic oil and gas pricing strategy has long been marked by inconsistency. While international crude prices remained low for extended periods, the benefits were rarely passed on to consumers. Yet whenever global prices rose, the burden was swiftly transferred to the public. The government also missed opportunities to strengthen strategic reserves during favourable market conditions, leaving the country more vulnerable during crises. The promotion of ethanol-blended fuel raises further concerns. Ethanol production is highly water-intensive, requiring significant quantities of water for every litre produced. This raises questions about its suitability for a water-stressed country like India. Comparisons with Brazil, which enjoys far greater water availability, may not be entirely appropriate. Moreover, consumers have seen little meaningful reduction in fuel prices despite higher blending targets. At the same time, India hosts one of the world's largest refining capacities, processing imported crude and exporting refined products.

These realities demand a more transparent and scientifically informed energy policy that balances affordability, sustainability and long-term energy security while safeguarding both consumers and national interests.

GIRISH R EDATHITTA | KERALA

India rightly raises maritime concerns

Prime Minister Narendra Modi's intervention at the G7 outreach session in Évian, highlighting the deaths of Indian seafarers aboard the Settebello, was both timely and necessary. The deaths of three Indian nationals on a vessel crewed largely by Indians underscore the human cost of geopolitical conflicts far beyond our shores. India supplies nearly 12 per cent of the world's seafarers. This contribution also exposes Indian families to disproportionate risks when strategic waterways such as the Strait of Hormuz become conflict zones. Civilian maritime workers often have little choice but to operate in dangerous conditions created by international tensions.

The call for a binding international convention on seafarer safety in conflict zones deserves serious attention. India should pursue this issue through concrete proposals at the International Maritime Organisation and the United Nations. Institutional safeguards may take time to establish, but they remain the most effective means of protecting civilian crews.

India's seafarers deserve legal protection commensurate with their contribution to global trade. Raising the issue at the G7 was important; sustained diplomatic action must now follow.

A MYLSAMI | COIMBATORE

DRUG SAFETY BEGINS WITH STRONGER REGULATION AND OVERSIGHT

The decision to make all cough syrups prescription-only appears to address the wrong problem. The recent deaths of children linked to contaminated cough syrups expose a serious failure in drug manufacturing and regulatory oversight, not in the manner of sale. A doctor's prescription cannot guarantee the quality or safety of a medicine if the product itself is contaminated before it reaches patients.

Repeated incidents of diethylene glycol (DEG) poisoning over several decades reveal persistent gaps in quality control and enforcement. Regulatory authorities must strengthen inspections, ensure strict compliance with manufacturing standards, and establish a transparent system for tracking raw materials and finished products throughout the supply chain. Companies found guilty of violating safety norms should face

stringent penalties, including permanent cancellation of licences. Officials responsible for oversight failures must also be held accountable. Equally important is the establishment of a robust drug recall mechanism to ensure that contaminated batches are swiftly removed from circulation. Hospitals and medical practitioners should be required to report unusual clusters of poisoning symptoms immediately, enabling authorities to intervene before more lives are lost. India is rightly regarded as the pharmacy of the world. To preserve that reputation, the government must prioritise quality control, accountability and enforcement rather than relying on prescription requirements that can be easily circumvented. Public health demands lasting reforms, not temporary fixes.

SANJAY CHOPRA | MOHALI

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The care economy:
India's invisible growth engine

In pursuit of a
drugs-free Bharat

As India seeks faster growth and a more inclusive development model, the care economy can no longer remain in the shadows. Recognising care as a form of economic infrastructure rather than a private household responsibility is not merely a question of social justice — it is a policy imperative for the country's future



In all cities and towns in India, an unseen economy operates behind the markets and formal workplaces: the economy of care. Nearly three times more than men's 97 minutes (NSSO), women spend 299 minutes per day on unpaid care work. This encompasses paid domestic work, elder care, childcare, and unpaid domestic labour within households, which helps millions of households to operate. However, despite contributing 15-17 per cent of India's GDP, care work is undervalued, unmeasured and poorly supported, with implications for gender equality, labour markets and social policy. Care is infrastructural labour, as it allows for paid work in various sectors. Women spend 16.9 per cent of their day in unpaid domestic work, and 2.6 per cent of their day in caregiving; men spend much less. However, this facilitating function tends not to be reflected in GDP or employment. The outcome is continuing policy neglect: investment that enhances care systems is viewed as a secondary objective of economic policy and not a priority.

The invisible care burden is most pronounced among the 'sandwich generation' of working people, particularly married people aged 35-54, who are caring for their children and ageing parents while also working. The sandwich generation is plagued by higher health-care and education costs, an ever-increasing need for loans and credit cards, inflation, and the desire for a better life. There will almost certainly be nearly three times the number of people in the 'sandwich generation' looking after 1.9 billion elderly family members worldwide by 2050. In India, women undertake most informal care work. Female participation in the labour force in India is 37 per cent, compared with the world average of 47.8 per cent. The growth of a strong care economy has the potential to drive FLPR to global levels, generating up to \$770 billion in GDP gains by 2025 (McKinsey). Approximately 4.2 million domestic workers are employed as caregivers, with no training or protection, many of whom are women from marginalised castes and migrant backgrounds. Such labourers do not have labour rights, social security or decent working conditions.

Economic and social costs

The absence of care has tangible impacts. Women's unpaid caring duties have negative effects on women's labour force participation, mobility and wages. The sandwich generation is just one example of this crisis: 76 per cent of them worry about becoming financially dependent on their children, while 71 per cent admit to fearing loneliness, even though 55 per cent feel secure about future family support. The added out-of-pocket costs for families who purchase private services or choose not to work are greater when they do not have reliable care options. Thirty-eight per cent of the sandwich generation are confident they will have enough saved to cover more than 10 years of retirement. When employees face multiple care crises, there are indirect costs to employers, including absenteeism and unproductive overtime. At the macro level, when care is not recognised, it limits human capital development and the effective use of the workforce.

Marketing care isn't the only answer

The market for care in India has been growing in recent years, with the introduction of day-care centres, private elder care homes, and app-based domestic worker platforms. Markets can increase access and generate paid employment, but can, if left unchecked, exacerbate inequality. Platformisation may perpetuate low wages and informal working conditions; privatised care is less of an option for some. In the absence of regulation, the market can cement fragile forms of employment and diversify responsibility for quality and safety.

Western lessons for India

Western countries provide contrasting models that



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Anuradha PS is Professor at CHRIST (Deemed to be University). She is a senior academician, researcher & columnist, and Divyashree is Professor at Alliance University. She is an academician and researcher with a PhD

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India can learn from and adapt to its context. Along with generous parental leave, parents in Sweden also receive subsidised childcare, which places them among the top countries in the OECD in terms of childcare benefits. Funded training programmes to skill and certify care workers, ensure quality and career progression, have been introduced in Canada. The National Disability Insurance Scheme (NDIS) in Australia sees care as an economic growth driver, with it forming part of national economic planning. In terms of public spending, OECD countries average 0.75 per cent of GDP on childcare, whereas the US invests only 0.33 per cent, which is less than half the average. Iceland is the highest-spending OECD country on childcare, spending five times more than the US. These models suggest that investment in public funding for care brings higher employment and greater workforce participation, and results in decent employment, while funding only by the private sector leads to greater inequalities and reproduces low-wage informal employment.

Policy levers that work

Public investment, regulation and cultural change are needed to recognise and support care. Key policy levers:

- Public provisioning: Increase affordable, high-quality childcare and after-school care and develop community-based eldercare services. Public centres alleviate private costs and create formal jobs.
- Labour protections: Formalise protections and social security for domestic workers and care workers, such as minimum wages, contracts, access to pensions and health insurance.
- Expanding paid family leave and flexible working options: Extend paid parental leave for both parents; create leave options for caregivers; and do not penalise career advancement for flexible working hours or telework.
- Time-use measurement: Periodically gather time-use data, quantify and make unpaid care visible in policy discussions and budget decisions.
- Fiscal prioritisation: Set aside funding lines for care workforce development and care services; consider care as infrastructure.
- Incorporate targeted programmes for middle-aged adults who are juggling care responsibilities for both parents and children.

Examples from Indian states

Community health workers, public anganwadis and school-based programmes have helped to alleviate household burdens. Pune and Bengaluru have introduced public day-care facilities and eldercare helplines as examples of how local governments can open up new space.

Reframing care as investment

The key change required is one of concept: shifting the perspective from care being a personal responsibility or duty to care being public infrastructure and an economic input. Government and employer investment in care services and consideration of care workers leads to higher labour force participation, better child and elder outcomes, and enhanced resilience in times of crisis, such as a pandemic or a climate shock. A strong care economy can help India achieve its goal of increasing FLPR from 37 per cent to 47.8 per cent, thereby generating \$770 billion in GDP benefits.

A policy imperative for India

In India, the issue of care policy is imperative given demographic and labour market changes. The population is becoming older, while more educated women and increasing urbanisation will increase demand for organised care. Without policy intervention, this imbalance in the burden of care will persist, slowing women's economic progress and maintaining the informal workforce. Care is the backbone of the economy. It's not about charity; it's about good public policy to make it visible and investable.



TUHIN A SINHA

For Union Home Minister Amit Shah, governance has increasingly come to mean setting seemingly impossible national targets and then relentlessly driving the state machinery to achieve them. His approach was visible in the Modi government's sustained rollback of Left-Wing Extremism, where the ambitious goal of a Naxal-free Bharat transformed from a political slogan into an administrative mission backed by hard deadlines, inter-agency coordination and uncompromising execution. Today, HM Amit Shah has set before the nation another sweeping objective: a completely drugs-free India by 2047. This is not merely another welfare slogan. For HM Shah, the narcotics menace represents a direct assault on India's demographic strength, social stability and national security. It is a threat that operates simultaneously through addition, organised crime, terror financing and black-money networks. That is why the Modi government's anti-drug campaign has evolved from isolated policing operations into a coordinated national security mission.

The seriousness with which HM Amit Shah views the issue became evident recently during "Operation RAGEPILL", when Indian agencies seized Captagon worth nearly ₹182 crore. Captagon, a dangerous synthetic stimulant often referred to internationally as the "jihadi drug", has been linked in global security discourse to extremist groups operating in conflict zones in parts of the Middle East. The seizure was therefore not just another narcotics bust. It symbolised the growing convergence between narco-trafficking, terror ecosystems and transnational criminal syndicates. Government-backed studies and international assessments suggest that nearly 7 to 8 crore Indians are affected, to varying degrees, by substance abuse, with the problem increasingly visible among adolescents and young adults. Millions require intervention for dependence on opioids, cannabis derivatives and synthetic narcotics.

India's illegal drug economy, fuelled by domestic syndicates and international trafficking routes, is estimated to run into tens of thousands of crores annually. India's geographical proximity to the Golden Crescent and Golden Triangle — the world's two major narcotics-producing hubs — makes the threat even more severe. A country cannot hope to harness its demographic dividend while simultaneously losing sections of its youth to addiction, criminality and narco-financed violence.

This explains why, under Prime Minister Narendra Modi and HM Amit Shah, narcotics control has been elevated into a whole-of-government mission involving the Narcotics Control Bureau, intelligence agencies, coastal security networks, border forces, state police units and financial enforcement bodies.

HM Amit Shah's governance style follows a recognisable template: define a bold objective, build institutional coordination and relentlessly monitor execution. The same model is now visible in the anti-drug campaign. Under his supervision, India has witnessed record seizures of heroin, methamphetamine, cocaine and synthetic narcotics. Maritime trafficking routes, darknet-enabled distribution systems and cross-border supply chains have all come under intensified scrutiny. Anti-drug operations are intelligence-driven and nationally coordinated.

Equally symbolic has been the large-scale destruction of confiscated narcotics worth thousands of crores. These destruction drives are not merely procedural exercises. They are designed to send a clear political message that the Indian state will show zero tolerance towards drug mafias. The recent "Operation RAGEPILL" seizure further reinforced the global dimensions of India's anti-drug effort. Authorities arrested a Syrian national while probing wider international trafficking links associated with the Captagon consignment. Such operations strengthen the government's argument that India is no longer dealing merely with localised narcotics syndicates, but with sophisticated transnational networks. The Modi government recognises that narcotics trafficking is inseparable from hawala operations, black money, money laundering and terror financing.

Consequently, agencies such as the Enforcement Directorate have intensified investigations into the financial infrastructure supporting narcotics syndicates. Properties linked to traffickers have been attached, shell companies investigated and illicit funding channels dismantled. The Home Ministry's position has been consistent: narco-money cannot be viewed in isolation. Drug proceeds often flow into organised crime, illegal arms procurement, separatist activity and extremist violence. Perhaps the most striking success story of this campaign has emerged in India's North-Eastern region. Historically vulnerable because of its proximity to the Golden Triangle, the region had long been exploited as a transit corridor for heroin and synthetic drugs entering India. Enhanced border surveillance, intelligence-sharing and anti-smuggling operations have led to repeated interceptions of narcotics consignments and the disruption of trafficking routes.

Importantly, the anti-drug effort in the North East has also been integrated with the Modi government's larger developmental vision for the region. Infrastructure expansion, connectivity projects and economic integration are viewed as long-term safeguards against narco-criminal ecosystems that thrive on instability and unemployment. The BJP has sought to draw a sharp contrast between the Centre's aggressive anti-drug posture and what it describes as the softer approach of certain opposition-ruled states.

In Punjab, the drug menace has become both a social tragedy and a political flash-point. Critics have repeatedly accused the government led by Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann and the Aam Aadmi Party of failing to decisively dismantle entrenched narcotics networks despite repeated promises. HM Amit Shah's larger political message is unmistakable. Much like terrorism and Naxalism, the narcotics menace too can be defeated through sustained political will, institutional coordination and uncompromising enforcement. His vision of a drugs-free Bharat by 2047 is ambitious, but so too once seemed the goal of rolling back Naxal violence across vast swathes of India. By linking narcotics trafficking with terrorism, organised crime and black money, HM Amit Shah has elevated the anti-drug campaign from a social issue to a strategic national mission. The message from the Home Ministry is now unequivocal: whether it is conventional narcotics or dangerous substances like the so-called "jihadi drug" Captagon, the Indian state will pursue traffickers relentlessly — across borders, across financial systems and across political patronage networks — until the vision of a drugs-free Bharat becomes reality.



The writer is a national spokesperson of the BJP and an acclaimed author

tuhinsinha1
 @tuhins
 tuhin-a-sinha-6388b490



important than ever. Yet, instead of enabling growth, the regulatory landscape governing agricultural inputs is becoming increasingly fragmented. A growing number of states are issuing their own rules, restrictions and administrative orders in areas already governed by central insecticide law, creating uncertainty for industry and raising a fundamental question: are states, in effect, superseding the Centre in agro-input regulation?

India's agriculture sector stands at a crucial juncture. As the country seeks to balance food security, transition towards a modern export-oriented economy, and promote ease of doing business, the role of regulation has become more important than ever. Yet, instead of enabling growth, the regulatory landscape governing agricultural inputs is becoming increasingly fragmented. A growing number of states are issuing their own rules, restrictions and administrative orders in areas already governed by central insecticide law, creating uncertainty for industry and raising a fundamental question: are states, in effect, superseding the Centre in agro-input regulation?

States are not necessarily enacting separate legislation but are increasingly using delegated authority, regulatory flexibility and enforcement mechanisms to introduce additional layers of control. These include state-specific licensing conditions, inspection drives, documentation requirements, stock reporting norms and product restrictions. While these measures are often justified in the name of farmer safety and quality assurance, they effectively create a parallel compliance structure for industry. Sampling of pesticides and fertilisers is essential to prevent the sale of substandard products. However, the process is not always implemented in a uniform or fully scientific manner. In Maharashtra, for instance, the central Insecticides Act, 1968, is being implemented along with state-specific amendments through the Amendment Act, 2023. There are also instances where non-technical personnel, such as campaign staff at the Zila Parishad level, are involved in inspections. This creates confusion among dealers and distributors and adds pressure on legitimate businesses. Industry stakeholders often describe this situation as an "inspector raj", as frequent inspections lead to operational difficulties not only for companies but also for farmers who depend on the timely availability of agri-inputs. At the same time, stricter penalties have been introduced for the sale of substandard pesticide products, including imprisonment and non-bailable offences. While the intent is to curb poor-quality and illegal trade, concerns remain regarding uneven enforcement, with inspections often focusing on established



compliant companies while "fly-by-night" operators escape scrutiny, reducing overall effectiveness. For India to achieve its goals of agricultural growth, innovation and farmer welfare, greater alignment between the Centre and the states is essential. States remain the first point of contact for farmers and play a crucial role in enforcement, but their actions should reinforce, not override, the central framework. Under Section 27 of the Insecticides Act, 1968, states can impose temporary bans on pesticide molecules for up to 60 days, extendable by another 30 days, with a maximum of 90 days. However, concerns arise when such restrictions are repeatedly extended or reimposed without fresh scientific evidence. For instance, Paraquat was banned in Odisha in 2023 and continues to remain unavailable for sale. Telangana recently imposed a 60-

day ban on the same molecule. Similarly, Punjab imposed a 60-day ban on 11 insecticides, including Acephate, Triazophos and Thiamethoxam. Meanwhile, the Punjab and Haryana High Court stayed a separate state ban on 12 pesticide molecules, citing an insufficient scientific basis. While working within the framework of the Insecticides Act, 1968, and the Insecticides Rules, 1971, states are increasingly introducing localised regulations and initiatives to oversee biopesticides. At the same time, although the biostimulant guidelines are not being opposed, gaps in implementation and interpretation at the ground level are leading to uncertainty. Divergent approaches across states, along with occasional restrictive actions such as those reported in Rajasthan, are further adding to the complexity of the regulatory environment. Additional conditions imposed by some states, such as mandatory stock reporting and movement restrictions, are disrupting the timely availability of fertilisers, especially during sowing seasons. By introducing localised rules for micronutrients beyond the Fertiliser Control Order, 1985, states are adding complexity, increasing compliance burdens and creating avoidable bottlenecks in the agricultural supply chain. Similar challenges are also seen in seed regulation, where additional requirements such as separate sale permissions, mandatory local trials and extra approval processes delay the rollout of new seed varieties. At the enforcement level, actions have also become increasingly stringent; for example, in Pune in 2024, the state agri-

culture department registered 149 court cases against seed companies, suspended 266 dealer licences, cancelled 485 licences, issued stop-sale orders to 1,044 retailers and filed 50 police cases in connection with the alleged supply of bogus seeds, reflecting the extent of regulatory enforcement at the field level. In some states, additional documentation, local office requirements, technical staffing details or affidavits beyond standard central requirements are being asked for. For example, the Haryana Government has even attempted to initiate proceedings against MDs, directors and CEOs of companies, reflecting the intensity of enforcement in certain jurisdictions. The State of Karnataka is emphasising the requirement for an affidavit from the director. These developments underline a growing structural imbalance in India's agro-input regulatory ecosystem. While states are essential for enforcement and farmer protection, excessive or inconsistent interventions risk creating uncertainty, disrupting supply chains and increasing compliance burdens. A harmonised, science-based regulatory framework anchored in coordination between the Centre and the states-is therefore critical. Only through cooperative federalism can India ensure that regulation strengthens farmer welfare while supporting innovation, trade efficiency and timely access to quality agricultural inputs.

The writer is the Director General of the Agrochem Federation of India (ACFI)

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UDF travel concession a poll promise: Kerala HC

The Kerala High Court on Thursday observed that the UDF administration's newly launched Priyadarshini Scheme, which offers free travel for women and transgender persons in ordinary KSRTC buses, was a fulfilment of its poll promise.

A bench of Chief Justice Soumen Sen and Justice Syam Kumar V M was also of the view that it was a policy decision of the government which was meant for the working class women.

"At least they have fulfilled their promise (made during elections)," the bench said while hearing the public interest litigation (PIL) by Muhammed Firdouz, who describes himself as a public-spirited citizen and taxpayer.

Advocate Shameem Ahamed MP, appearing for the petitioner, told the bench that the scheme was "discriminatory" and violative of Articles 14 and 15 of the Constitution as it provides free bus travel to women and transgender persons without any income limit, residential qualification or identified disadvantage that it seeks to address.

On the other hand, the government told the court that similar schemes have been implemented in Delhi, Punjab, Karnataka, Tamil Nadu, Telangana and West Bengal.

After hearing both sides, the court reserved its judgement in the matter.



(PTI)

Need to protect forests across the country, observes SC

The Supreme Court on Thursday said there was a need to protect forests across India, noting that some states like Jharkhand have natural ecosystems which must be preserved.

The observations came from a bench of Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justice V Mohana which was hearing a plea filed by the Jharkhand State Pollution Control Board (JSPCB). "There are few states where we can really protect our natural ecosystem and you (Jharkhand) are one of them," the CJL told the counsel appearing for the JSPCB. The bench observed that some of the states have natural paradises like forests and they need to be protected. The top court was hearing a petition challenging an order of the Jharkhand High Court.

The high court had in April passed directions relating to consent for stone mining or establishing stone crushers from the boundaries of forests or forest land. In January, the high court had directed that no consent should be granted for stone mining or stone crushers within one km measured from the demarcated boundaries of protected forests within the state. The high court had passed the order in January while hearing a petition challenging a notification issued by the JSPCB which reduces the minimum distance for setting up stone mines and stone crushers around forest or forest land from the previously notified 400-500 metres to 250 metres.

In its April order, the high court had said the restriction on the grant of consents would apply to the zone of 500 metres from the boundaries of forests or forest land insofar as stone mining was concerned, and to the zone of 400 metres insofar as stone crushers were concerned. During the hearing on Thursday, the top court observed the authority had abruptly reduced the distance.



(PTI)

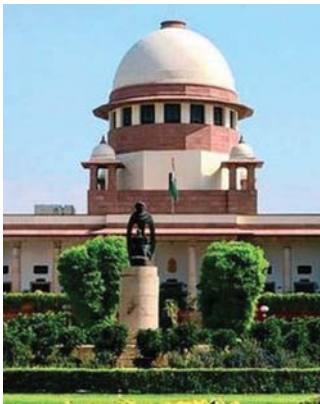
SC seeks response on national registry of legal professions

The Supreme Court on Thursday sought responses from the Centre, Bar Council of India, and others on a plea seeking a direction to establish a national digital registry of legal professions in India, including a unique national advocate identifier for every enrolled lawyer, to curb fake practitioners.

A bench of Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justice V Mohana observed that the idea appeared innovative and could be done with the help of technology. The petition, filed by the Bar Association of India (BAI), has also sought a direction to the Bar Council of India (BCI) to frame a social media and digital conduct code under Section 49 of the Advocates Act, 1961.

Advocates Vipin Nair and Prashant Kumar appeared for the BAI. The top court issued notice to the Centre, BCI, the University Grants Commission (UGC), and others, seeking their responses to the plea, and posted it for hearing in July. During the hearing, the CJL stressed the need to strengthen the young members of the Bar and said they must be encouraged.

(PTI)



SC refuses interim order on plea against CBSE's 3-language policy

PIONEER NEW SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Thursday refused to pass any interim order on a plea challenging the implementation of a CBSE policy mandating the study of three languages, including two native Indian languages, for Class 9 students from the 2026-27 academic session.

A bench of Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justice V Mohana tagged the plea filed by NGO Friends of People for

Active Democracy with similar petitions pending on the issue.

"We cannot pass a single-line order today. This matter was argued at length. There is no question of interim protection," the bench said as it ordered the tagging of the matter. During the brief hearing, the counsel appearing for the NGO submitted that they are not challenging the three-language policy per se but just the implementation part of it.

CJI Kant then questioned the NGO's name, Friends Of People



For Active Democracy, and asked in a lighter vein if that kind of nomenclature was meant to create fear in the

mind of the court or the people. The counsel replied, "No, my lord. That's the name of the trust. It's an old trust set up in 2013", and submitted that the CBSE was required to issue detailed guidelines by June 15.

The bench, however, listed the matter for hearing on July 14 along with other pending petitions.

On May 27, the top court agreed to examine the plea challenging a CBSE policy mandating the study of three languages and issued notices to the Centre, the CBSE and the

NCERT and sought comprehensive replies within two weeks. It had asked ASG Aishwarya Bhati to submit a report on the logistical preparedness of the CBSE to implement the decision and posted the matter for hearing in the second week of July.

According to a recent circular issued by the Central Board of Secondary Education (CBSE), the study of three languages, including at least two native Indian languages, has been made compulsory for Class 9 students beginning July 1.

The move is part of the CBSE's alignment of its scheme of studies with the National Education Policy (NEP) 2020 and the National Curriculum Framework for School Education (NCF-SE) 2023.

"In order to adequately address the competencies envisaged at the Secondary Stage, these textbooks will be supplemented with one appropriate local or state literary material, selected by schools, such as short stories, poems, or nonfiction works," the board said.

Calcutta HC refuses interim order on LoP naming

PIONEER NEW SERVICE
■ Kolkata

The Calcutta High Court on Thursday refused any interim order on the West Bengal Assembly Speaker Rathindra Bose's decision to appoint breakaway TMC group MLA Ritabrata Banerjee as the Leader of Opposition.

TMC legislator Sobhandeb Chattopadhyay moved the court, challenging the rejection of his nomination for the post and the appointment of Banerjee as the Leader of Opposition by the Speaker.

Justice Krishna Rao, refusing any interim order as prayed for by Chattopadhyay on the Speaker's decision, directed that the matter would appear for hearing again on July 28.

With the budget session of the state assembly commencing on Thursday, and scheduled to conclude business on June 25, the court's refusal to intervene in the matter effectively meant that the Speaker-approved office bearers of the rebel TMC group would continue to function in their respective positions for now.



The Speaker granted approval of Banerjee as LoP, Javed Khan, Sandipan Saha, Sabina Yeasmin, and Seuli Saha as deputy leaders and Akhruzzaman as the chief whip. The court directed the respondents in the petition to file affidavits within three weeks. The petitioner will have the opportunity to reply to the affidavits within the subsequent two weeks, Justice Rao said. The breakaway group has claimed the support of 58 of the total 80 TMC MLAs in the West Bengal assembly.

Chattopadhyay, who belongs to the Mamata Banerjee-led group, had sought an interim order by the court on the ground that the first session of the 18th

West Bengal Assembly was scheduled to commence on Thursday.

During the course of its hearings, the court, while making observations, raised questions over the procedure followed by the Assembly Speaker in appointing the LoP when two conflicting proposals were received from the same political party for the office-bearer positions.

The bench remarked that since two proposals were received by the Speaker, how could he, "sitting in his chamber, decide on his own which one is right and which is wrong, without calling the House to prove their majority?" The court had sought clarity on the Speaker's duty under such circumstances, whether he decides suo motu between the two, or does he need to give both an opportunity of hearing?

The judge had also asked the additional advocate general and the Speaker's counsel, Billwadal Bhattacharya, whether he was waiting for an objection from the dissidents to come after

the initial proposal of office bearers was sent by the party.

TMC's MLA from Entally in central Kolkata, Sandipan Saha, called the court's stance a "moral victory" for the dissident legislators.

Saha is one of the two complainants against TMC national general secretary Abhishek Banerjee's letter of endorsement for Sobhandeb Chattopadhyay as LoP.

"This is our moral victory since more than 58 MLAs signed their letters of support for Ritabrata Banerjee as LoP and handed them over to the Speaker in compliance with the existing legal provisions. Our numbers have now grown much beyond that initial figure," Saha told reporters on the state assembly premises. "We will move ahead with the purpose with which our principal opposition bloc was formed," he added.

As opposed to the Mamata Banerjee and Abhishek Banerjee-led section of the TMC MLAs, the ones led by Ritabrata have labelled themselves the "real TMC" in the state assembly.

Ensure alternative arrangements during Red Road closure for Yoga Day: Calcutta HC

PIONEER NEW SERVICE
■ Kolkata

The Calcutta High Court on Thursday directed the West Bengal government to make alternative traffic arrangements to minimise inconvenience to commuters during the closure of Red Road for preparations for the International Day of Yoga programme, which will be led by Prime Minister Narendra Modi on June 21.

Hearing a petition filed by the All India Lawyers' Union (AILU), Justice Saugata Bhattacharyya also directed the police authorities to take immediate steps to reopen Red Road for public use once the event concludes.

The petitioner challenged the prolonged closure of the iconic thoroughfare since June 14, contending that it was causing inconvenience to the lawyers belonging to the petitioner organisation travelling to and from the high court.

The court directed the



police to ensure that suitable alternative routes remain available for members of the petitioner organisation as well as the general public to reach their workplaces and destinations while Red Road remains closed.

Senior advocate Bikash Ranjan Bhattacharya, appearing for the petitioners, argued that the Kolkata Police Commissioner lacked the authority to keep the road closed for such an extended period and sought quashing of the notification

imposing the restriction.

Observing that the validity of the notification had been challenged, Justice Bhattacharyya said the issue would be examined after affidavits are filed by the parties.

The court directed the state government to file its affidavit within three weeks, with the petitioner allowed one additional week to file a reply. The matter will be taken up for further hearing thereafter.

Justice Bhattacharyya also

instructed the petitioners to implead the Defence Ministry as a respondent, noting that Red Road is situated on land owned by the Indian Army's Eastern Command.

Appearing for the state, Additional Advocate General Billwadal Bhattacharya submitted that the event is being organised by the West Bengal government in collaboration with the Ministry of Ayush to mark International Day of Yoga.

"India will be leading the world from Kolkata," he told the court.

The judge queried whether the programme could have been held at the nearby Brigade Parade Ground instead of Red Road to avoid disruption to public movement.

The AAG responded that several alternative routes were available in the area and assured the court that commuters, including members of the petitioner organisation, would not face undue inconvenience.

Thane court acquits three in constable assault case

PIONEER NEW SERVICE
■ Thane

A Thane court has acquitted three men accused of assaulting and intimidating a police constable in 2018, ruling that the prosecution's case was doubtful and the investigation officer suppressed the fact that the cop was himself under the influence of liquor.

The defence of the accused that they were assaulted by the constable and other witnesses seems to be probable, Additional Sessions Judge GT Pawar said in the order on Wednesday.

According to the prosecution, constable Navnath Sadashiv Thorve, the informant in the case, stopped a motorcycle at Yeoor Gate in Maharashtra's Thane city and found the riders drunk on March 2, 2018, when the Holi festival was being celebrated.

When their vehicle was seized, the accused allegedly hurled abuses and slapped the informant, the prosecution said. However, the medical evidence turned the case. The court observed that



the medical officer testified that the informant was heavily intoxicated during his examination.

From perusal of the evidence, it seems that the investigation officer intentionally collected an incomplete medico-legal case report by omitting the fact that at the time of examination, the informant was under the influence of liquor, the court said. "He was not answering the questions put to him and was talking irrelevantly, and his central nervous system was disoriented," it noted.

"Hence, the entire prosecu-

tion story seems to be doubtful and the defence of the accused that they were assaulted by the informant and witnesses seems to be probable," the court said.

It also noted that the police failed to produce any breath analyser reports, could not explain the injuries sustained by the accused, and presented contradictory eyewitness testimonies, rendering the allegations completely unbelievable.

The court then acquitted Mujaram alias Rambhau Bapurao Yenkure (40), Sunil Ganpat Rokade (40), and Balu Bapurao Yenkure (36).

OFCD case: SC to hear SEBI plea against SAT relief to SICCL staff

PIONEER NEW SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Thursday agreed to hear a plea by the Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) challenging a part of the Securities Appellate Tribunal order granting relief to four managers and the company secretary of Sahara India Commercial Corporation Ltd (SICCL).

A bench of Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justice V Mohana tagged the matter with the pending petitions on the issue and listed it in the month of July.

On March 9, the tribunal upheld regulatory action by the SEBI against SICCL and dismissed appeals filed by the company and its directors in connection with the alleged illegal issuance of optionally fully convertible debentures (OFCDs).

The three-member SAT bench had ruled that the OFCDs issued by SICCL between 1998 and 2008 constituted a public offer, bringing them within SEBI's



regulatory jurisdiction.

The tribunal had said that the SICCL mobilised around ₹14,106 crore from nearly 1.98 crore investors through these debentures during the period. It also held that such a large-scale mobilisation of funds from such a huge number of investors could not be treated as a private placement, as claimed by the company.

While dismissing the appeals filed by SICCL and its directors, the tribunal had allowed a separate appeal filed by four managers and the company secretary, while holding that as employees they could not be held liable

for the company's actions.

It also noted that the prospectus had been signed by the company secretary pursuant to powers of attorney granted by the directors, who remained responsible as principals for the acts of their agent.

The SEBI has now challenged that part of the ruling before the apex court.

The case pertains to an October 2018 order passed by SEBI directing the company to refund the money raised through the debentures, disclose details of its inventory, and debarring certain officials from accessing the securities market.



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The case stems from an incident in Alappuzha in December 2023 when Youth Congress activists staged a black-flag protest against the then CPI(M)-led government as Pinarayi Vijayan and his ministers travelled through the district as part of the Nava Kerala Sadas outreach programme.

According to the prosecution, the protesters were assaulted with sticks by the chief minister's gunmen after they ran towards the bus carrying Vijayan.

Ex-RCom official sent to judicial custody till July 1

PIONEER NEW SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A Delhi court on Thursday remanded former Reliance Communications (RCom) senior executive Gautam Bhailal Doshi to judicial custody till July 1 in a money laundering case linked to the alleged diversion of loan funds worth over ₹40,000 crore. Vacation Judge Rajesh Malik sent Doshi to jail on being produced following the expiry of five days of custody granted to the agency on June 13.

Doshi, a former senior officer of RCom, was arrested by the ED in connection with its probe under the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA). The ED had arrested Doshi and brought him to Delhi from Mumbai on transit remand.

The ED had alleged that its investigation revealed a fund trail involving diversion of loan funds from Reliance ADA Group entities to foreign remittances, offshore companies and



foreign bank accounts.

According to the agency, loans availed from banks were allegedly not utilised for their intended purposes and were instead invested in mutual funds and transferred to group companies. The ED had told the court that Doshi occupied a position of substantial authority and control within the Reliance ADA Group and was closely associated with its financial, corporate and offshore operations.

The agency alleged that he functioned as one of the group managing directors of the Reliance ADA Group, was a director of Reliance Telecom Ltd during the relevant period and also served as a member of its audit committee.

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Sensex gains 254 points as markets rally fifth straight Day

Benchmark equity indices Sensex and Nifty ended in positive territory on Thursday, rallying for the fifth straight session, supported by encouraging developments on the geopolitical front and easing crude oil prices. The 30-share BSE Sensex climbed 254.36 points, or 0.33 per cent, to settle at 77,409.98. During the day, the benchmark hit a high of 77,492.33 and a low of 76,953, gyrating 539.33 points. The 50-share NSE Nifty edged higher by 82.30 points, or 0.34 per cent, to end at 24,168. From the 30-Sensex firms, InterGlobe Aviation, Trent, Bharat Electronics, NTPC, State Bank of India, and HDFC Bank were among the biggest winners. Infosys, Tech Mahindra, Maruti, and Tata Consultancy Services were among the laggards. Brent crude, the global oil benchmark, dropped 2.23 per cent to \$77.78 per barrel. US President Donald Trump signed a Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) with Iran during a dinner at the Palace of Versailles in France on Wednesday to end the over three-month war. "The domestic equities traded within a range, maintaining a positive bias as the initial optimism surrounding the US-Iran peace deal was tempered by hawkish remarks from the US Fed. Energy-driven inflationary pressures may prompt central banks to consider rate hikes in the latter half of the year, leading investors to adopt a cautious stance," Vinod Nair, Head of Research, Geojit Investments Ltd, said. However, the sustained decline in crude oil prices and moderation in Indian bond yields could offset inflationary concerns in the second half of FY27, with market participants awaiting further clarity on the peace agreement, he added. (PTI)

India to allow 3.78 lakh UK cars at lower duty

India will allow import of up to 3.78 lakh units of conventional-engine passenger cars, including mass-market models, from the UK at concessional import duty during the first 15 years of the implementation of the bilateral trade pact, which will come into force from July 15. Under the comprehensive economic and trade agreement (CETA), import duties on automotive products will fall from about 110 per cent to 10 per cent, with quotas on both sides. According to the India-UK CETA document, released, India will get access to the UK's electric, hybrid/hydrogen passenger cars segment with duty-free exports to that country from the sixth year in the price segment ranging from GBP 20,000 to GBP 80,000, with the total quota reaching a peak of 88,000 units from the 15th year and continuing in the subsequent years. This will benefit Indian manufacturers such as Tata Motors Passenger Vehicles, Mahindra & Mahindra, and Maruti Suzuki, among others. The two countries announced the implementation of CETA from July 15. For imports from the UK to India, the quota for conventional-engine passenger cars will peak in the fifth year across specified categories of vehicles at 37,000 units, with customs duties reduction reaching a final 10 per cent. The duties will not be reduced beyond this. In the first year, the quota for passenger cars of engine size more than 3,000 cc (petrol) and over 2,500 cc (diesel) is 10,000 units, with customs duty being reduced to 30 per cent from 110 per cent. For cars with engine size of 1,500 cc (petrol), 2500 cc (diesel) and 3,000 cc (petrol), the quota is 5,000 units, with duty being reduced to 50 per cent from 66 per cent. In the mass market segment of engine size of up to 1,500 cc, the allowed quota of import in the first year of the pact is 5,000 units, with customs duty being reduced to 50 per cent from 66 per cent, as per the document. (PTI)

RBI cancels licence of Shree Mahalaxmi Urban Co-operative Credit Bank

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

The Reserve Bank has cancelled the licence of Karnataka-based Shree Mahalaxmi Urban Co-operative Credit Bank due to its worsening financial position. The Registrar of Co-operative Societies, Karnataka has also been requested to issue an order for winding up the bank and appoint a liquidator, the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) said in a statement on Thursday.

On liquidation, about 97.9 per cent of depositors would receive full amount of their deposits from Deposit Insurance and Credit Guarantee Corporation (DICGC). Giving reasons for cancellation of the licence, the RBI said the lender does not have adequate capital and earning prospects and does not comply with certain provisions of the

Banking Regulation Act, 1949. "The bank with its present financial position would be unable to pay its present depositors in full," it said, and added continuation of the bank will be prejudicial to the interests of its depositors.

The Pioneer

NEW DELHI | FRIDAY | JUNE 19, 2026

NSE warns tech failures, AI risks could hit business

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The National Stock Exchange (NSE) has warned that regulatory changes, technology failures, cyberattacks and AI-related risks, coupled with its significant dependence on derivatives trading revenues, could materially affect its financial performance and business operations.

In its draft red herring prospectus (DRHP) filed on Wednesday, the country's largest stock exchange said transaction charges accounted for 78.65 per cent of its operating revenue in FY26, with options trading alone contributing 60.22 per cent of total revenue from opera-

tions. The exchange said recent regulatory measures introduced by the Securities and Exchange Board of India (Sebi) to strengthen the equity derivatives framework have already led to moderation in trading activity across cash and derivatives segments, resulting in lower trading revenues during FY26.

NSE warned that any further tightening of regulations, higher transaction taxes, shifts in investor preferences or migration towards alternative asset classes could adversely affect trading volumes and profitability. The exchange also highlighted extensive regulatory risks, noting that it remains subject to continuous over-

sight, inspections and enforcement actions by Sebi.

NSE disclosed that it has received show-cause notices, warning letters, deficiency letters and advisory communications from the market regulator on operational, gov-

ernance, technology and compliance-related matters.

The bourse said it has incurred substantial settlement costs in recent years, including a payment of more than Rs 643 crore in October 2024 in connection with pro-

Emirates NBD to hold 60% in RBL Bank

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

RBL Bank on Thursday said it will allot equity shares worth ₹26,015 crore to Emirates NBD Bank, and has classified the Dubai-based bank as a promoter with a 60 per cent holding. In a regulatory filing, RBL Bank said its board has approved the allotment of over 92.91 crore equity shares at ₹280/share, aggregating to ₹26,015 crore by way of a preferential issue on a private place-

ment basis. "Emirates NBD Bank (PJSC) has been classified as a promoter of the Bank," RBL Bank said in the filing. Also, RBL Bank has approved the reconstruction of its board. Shayne Keith Nelson, Patrick John Sullivan, Neeraj Makin, Manoj Chawla and Marwan

Mahmood Mohammad Hadi have been appointed as (Additional) Non-Executive Non-Independent Directors on the RBL Bank board with effect from June 18.

They will be the nominees of Emirates NBD Bank on RBL's board. Besides, Gopal Jain and Veena Mankar have resigned as non-executive non-independent directors of the Bank, with effect from Thursday. Shares of RBL Bank were

trading at ₹372.25, up 0.92 per cent over the previous close on BSE.

In April, the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) had allowed Emirates NBD Bank to acquire up to 74 per cent stake in RBL Bank, while the finance ministry gave its approval in May.

The approval was granted following Emirates NBD Bank, the second largest in the UAE, expressing its interest in October 2025 to acquire a majority 60 per cent stake in RBL Bank for ₹26,853 crore. Emirates NBD (ENBD) would acquire and maintain a shareholding of at least 51 per cent of the paid-up share capital of RBL Bank, and the bank would be classified as a foreign bank in subsidiary mode, with the investor as its parent foreign bank.

NSE IPO to unlock multi-crore gains for shareholders

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The much-awaited initial public offering (IPO) of the National Stock Exchange (NSE) is set to unlock significant value for its existing shareholders, with institutional investors, financial entities and industry veterans expected to reap gains worth thousands of crores.

The country's largest stock exchange filed its draft papers with market regulator Sebi for its mega-IPO, estimated at around ₹30,000 crore.

The offering, which will be entirely an Offer for Sale (OFS), is set to become the largest public issue in Indian stock market history. At the estimated size, the NSE share-sale will surpass the ₹27,870 crore IPO of Hyundai Motor India, which was launched in October 2024 and currently holds the record of the

biggest IPO in the country.

Based on the prevailing unlisted market price of around ₹2,000 per share, billionaire investor and DMart founder Radhakishan Damani's 3.91 crore shares, representing a 1.58 per cent stake in NSE, are valued at about ₹7,817 crore, making him one of the biggest individual beneficiaries of the

proposed listing. Hero Enterprise Chairman Sunil Kant Munjal's 1.02 crore shares, or a 0.41 per cent stake, are worth around ₹2,040 crore, while Infosys co-founder S Gopalakrishnan's 94.29 lakh shares, representing a 0.38 per cent holding, are valued at nearly ₹1,886 crore. Individual investor Siddharth Balachandran's 0.38 per cent stake is estimated to be worth about ₹1,863 crore at current unlisted market valuations.

The IPO comprises the sale of 14.89 crore shares by existing shareholders, who will collectively divest nearly 6 per cent of their stake in the exchange.

Among selling shareholders, State Bank of India (SBI) is expected to emerge as the largest beneficiary. The country's largest lender plans to offload 2.47 crore shares, potentially generating nearly

₹4,950 crore based on current unlisted market prices. Notably, SBI's weighted average acquisition cost stands at just 80 paise per share, suggesting the substantial appreciation the NSE has generated over the years.

Mauritius-based MS Strategic is expected to realise around ₹3,200 crore through the sale of 1.6 crore shares, while Canadian pension fund CPPIB could garner around ₹2,375 crore. Aranda Investments is likely to sell shares worth nearly ₹2,250 crore.

Other major sellers include Bank of Baroda, which could receive around ₹2,197 crore, followed by Stock Holding Corporation of India (₹2,178 crore), General Insurance Corporation of India (₹2,131 crore), and The New India Assurance Company Ltd (₹2,100 crore).

Union Minister launches smart warehousing system of CWC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Union Food Minister Pralhad Joshi on Thursday launched the smart warehousing system of state-owned Central Warehousing Corporations (CWC) that uses modern technologies like AI to help monitor inventory and real-time operations in 216 grain warehouses through integrated dashboards.

Foodgrains meant for distribution through the Public Distribution System (PDS) are stored in CWC and FCI depots. The smart warehousing system is being introduced to ensure transparency and curb foodgrains diversion.

After the launch, Joshi said, "It is our responsibility to

keep the foodgrains safe and secure", and use of technologies is helping strengthen the PDS. Smart warehousing is not only a technology initiative, but it is also a food security initiative, he said.

Under smart warehousing system, 216 CWC warehouses are equipped with a surveillance system to ensure foodgrains are stored in a scientific manner, not susceptible to proliferation," Food Secretary Sanjeev Chopra said.

Very shortly, FCI will follow suit. About 150 FCI warehouses will be under the smart warehousing system by October, he said.

RBI approves extension of Keki Mistry's tenure

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

HDFC Bank on Thursday said the Reserve Bank has approved the extension of Keki Mistry's tenure as interim chairman for three months till September 18.

Mistry, a veteran of the HDFC Bank Group, was appointed as the interim chairman on March 18, following resignation of the bank's non-executive chairman Atanu Chakraborty.

Chakraborty had resigned from the bank raising concerns over its functioning, and said that certain practices within the bank over the last two years are not in "congruence" with his "personal values and ethics".

In a regulatory filing on June 18, HDFC Bank said it had made an application to the

RBI seeking extension of Mistry's tenure.

"...the RBI, vide its communication dated June 18, 2026, has granted approval for the extension of tenure of Keki Mistry as an interim Part-time Chairman of the Bank for a further period of 3 (three) months until September 18, 2026 or till appointment of a regular Part-time Chairman, whichever is earlier," HDFC Bank said in a regulatory filing.

Silver futures plunge by ₹8,817

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Silver futures plunged by ₹8,817 to ₹2.42 lakh per kg on Thursday, tracking weak global trends after the US Federal Reserve's latest policy signals strengthened the dollar and dampened investors' appetite for precious metals.

On the Multi Commodity Exchange, the white metal for July delivery declined by ₹8,817, or 3.5 per cent, to ₹2,42,990 per kilogram in a business turnover of 11,188 lots. Analysts said the decline came after the US central

bank kept interest rates unchanged, but indicated that the fight against inflation remains far from over, prompting traders to reassess

expectations for future monetary policy easing. Silver prices in the domestic markets saw a sharper decline of more than 3 per cent on Thursday, Gaurav Garg, Research Analyst at Lemonn Markets Desk, said.

"The downturn in precious metals can be attributed to a strengthening US dollar, as traders remain wary following a hawkish June Federal Reserve policy decision under new Chair Kevin Warsh," he said. In the international markets, Comex silver futures for the July contract declined \$2.36, or 3.34 per cent, to \$68.40 per ounce in New York.

CIABC welcomes CETA, urges States to ensure fair competition

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Confederation of Indian Alcoholic Beverage Companies (CIABC) has welcomed the announcement that the India-UK Comprehensive Economic and Trade Agreement (CETA) will come into force from July 15, 2026. The agreement marks an important milestone in India-UK economic relations and is expected to strengthen bilateral trade, investment and market access across sectors.

Alcoholic beverages have been an important part of the India-UK trade discussions. CIABC appreciates that the

tariff reduction on imported spirits will be phased over a period of 10 years, allowing the domestic industry time to adjust. Lower import duty on Scotch whisky will also help Indian producers using Scotch as an input for bottled-in-India products.

However, with customs duty on imported spirits now set to reduce under CETA, it

becomes essential to address the State-level policy distortions that currently favour Bottled-in-Origin imported products over comparable Indian-made products in several markets.

In a number of States, like Delhi, Haryana, Maharashtra, Madhya Pradesh, Odisha, Assam and Kerala BIO products already benefit from lower duties, lower brand registration fees, lower VAT/sales tax, corporation margins or greater market-access flexibility. Once customs duty reduction takes effect, these State-level concessions could create a double advantage for imported products: first through

reduced import duty and second through favourable local excise treatment.

CIABC believes that State Governments should now review and withdraw preferential treatment extended to BIO products wherever such treatment creates a structural disadvantage for Indian-made products.

The objective is not to restrict consumer choice, but to ensure competitive neutrality between domestically produced IMFL, bottled-in-India products and BIO imports operating in the same premium segments. Within this premium and above category, BIO products account 25% of the

segment and growing, making policy neutrality in this space critical for the future of Indian premium brands.

Any policy structure that makes imported products structurally more attractive than Indian-made products weakens the domestic value chain and runs contrary to the spirit of Make in India, Vocal for Local and Atmanirbhar Bharat. CIABC therefore urges State Governments to move towards parity-based excise design in the premium and above segments where Indian brands are now gaining recognition in India and globally.

India emerges top global energy gainer : Report

Index 2026, recording one of the largest gains in transition readiness and strengthening its position as a key player in the next phase of the global energy transition," the WEF said. It attributed India's improvement to stronger

energy transition readiness and broad-based system gains, driven by a sharp rise in infrastructure, alongside improvements in equity, sustainability and financial investment. The proportion of low-carbon jobs increased by 24 per cent in India in 2024, as renewable energy jobs reached 1.3 million (up 25 per cent over 2023), with hydropower being the largest employment source.

The report also underlined scaling renewable capacity, grid expansion and green hydrogen under its infrastructure-led clean-energy strategy as key focus areas for India.

FROM THE WORLD

NEPAL

5 Indians held for kidnapping

Five Indian teenagers have been arrested in Nepal for allegedly kidnapping a 15-year-old boy in Kathmandu, police said on Thursday.

According to the police, the teenagers kidnapped a Nepalese boy from Chitwan district, 150 kilometres south of Kathmandu, on Monday.

The boy was kept as a hostage in a hotel in Kathmandu, and the kidnapers had demanded ransom from the family, they added.

Acting on a tip, the police raided the Hotel on Tuesday and arrested those involved in the kidnapping.Police said that all the arrested individuals are 18-year-old boys from Betia, Bihar. The kidnapped boy was not harmed during the rescue operation, police added.

The arrested teenagers have been sent to the Chitawan District Police for further investigation and legal action, they added.

UK

Official jailed for spying

A former UK border official and a retired Hong Kong police officer were given prison sentences on Friday for spying on dissidents and critics of Beijing in Britain.Border Force officer Peter Wai and Bill Yuen, a former superintendent in the Hong Kong Police, posed as police or intelligence officers to conduct surveillance and gather information about Hong Kong dissidents and pro-democracy supporters, prosecutors said.Their targets included former Hong Kong lawmaker Nathan Law and activists they referred to as “cockroaches,” as well as British politicians critical of China, according to the prosecutors. A jury found the two Chinese-British nationals guilty last month of breaching the National Security Act by assisting a foreign intelligence service. Wai was also convicted of misconduct in a public office for using a Government computer to seek information on people of interest to the Hong Kong authorities.

Iran, US peace deal offers mutual strategic gains

LEE KEATH ■ Cairo

The interim deal reached by the United States and Iran to end their war will reopen the Strait of Hormuz and bring the two adversaries back to the negotiating table over Tehran’s nuclear program. It will also give Iran an immediate benefit, allowing it to sell its oil freely again, according to details released by both countries.

Besides the new oil revenue for Iran, the two sides are more or less back where they were 3½ months ago — before Israel and the US

launched their war, which has left thousands dead across the region, triggered a global energy crisis and shaken the American economy. Iran and the US will enter a 60-day period of negotiations, and hanging over them will be the question of whether US President Donald Trump can wrest a better deal than the 2015 nuclear accord he scuttled eight years ago.

Trump signed a physical copy of the deal Wednesday while dining with French President Emmanuel Macron at the Palace of Versailles.

In Tehran, President Masoud Pezeshkian signed the document, according to the state-run IRNA news agency, which posted an image of him holding up the deal with his signature and Trump’s.

Under the agreement, the Strait of Hormuz will reopen, and the US will lift its blockade of Iranian ports — both of which should push gas prices down.

Passage through the waterway will be toll-free for 60 days, and the deal doesn’t preclude fees after that, according to US officials who spoke on the condition of anonymity to read details of the draft, which has not yet been officially released by Washington. Iran’s closure of the strait, through which around a fifth of the world’s traded oil supplies passed before the war,



proved perhaps its strongest weapon. It drove up global fuel prices, made food and other products like fertilizer more expensive, and helped push US inflation to 4 per cent ahead of this fall’s midterm congressional elections.

With the deal in place, the Islamic Republic has survived the most serious attempt ever by Israel and the United States to topple its Government, despite the thundering opening volleys of the war that killed Iran’s supreme leader and other top officials.

The deal immediately waives, but doesn’t eliminate, sanctions that Trump imposed on Iran’s oil exports, allowing it once again sell its crude on the world market and restoring a revenue stream worth billions.

Last year, Iran earned an estimated \$45 billion from oil sales. But it had only one major buyer, China, and had to ship its crude through a shadow fleet of tankers to elude sanctions, eating into its profits. Under the blockade since April, its exports have nearly ground to a halt. With the waiver, Iran will likely

be able to find more customers and sell its oil for higher prices. The draft agreement calls for Iran’s highly enriched uranium to be “downblended” - or diluted - under the supervision of the International Atomic Energy Agency, without elaborating. Negotiations on any other restrictions on Tehran’s nuclear program lie ahead.

Trump withdrew from a previous nuclear deal with world powers, criticizing it for giving a huge wind-fall to Iran. But the interim deal outlines even more lucrative incentives if Iran reaches a new nuclear agreement. One is the eventual lifting of all international sanctions, which would seem to go further than the 2015 accord. That agreement lifted sanctions related to Iran’s nuclear program but kept others in place over what the U.S. alleged were Tehran’s support for terrorism and rights abuses.

The interim pact also promises a \$300 billion fund for postwar reconstruction. It’s not clear where that money will come from - but Trump said the US would not contribute. (AP)

TEXT OF THE DEAL	
- The United States of America and the Islamic Republic of Iran and their allies in the current war by signing this MOU declare the immediate and permanent termination of military operations on all fronts, including in Lebanon, and undertake from now on not to initiate any war or any military operation against each other and to refrain from the threat or use of force against each other and ensuring the territorial integrity and sovereignty of Lebanon. The final deal will confirm the permanent termination of the war on all fronts including in Lebanon and other provisions of this paragraph. - The United States of America and the Islamic Republic of Iran undertake to respect each other’s sovereignty and territorial integrity and to refrain from interfering in each other’s internal affairs. - The United States of America and the Islamic Republic of Iran commit to negotiating and achieving the final deal in maximum 60 days extendable with mutual consent. - Immediately upon the signing of this MOU, the United States of America will begin the removal of its naval blockade and any disturbances or impediments against the Islamic Republic of Iran and will fully end the naval blockade within 30 days. During this period, the traffic of vessels will be in proportion to the numbers of prewar traffic being restored by the Islamic Republic of Iran. The United States of America further undertakes to remove its forces from the proximity of the Islamic Republic of Iran within 30 days after the final deal. - Upon the signing of this MOU, the Islamic Republic of Iran will make arrangements using its best efforts for the safe passage of commercial vessels with no charge for 60 days only from the Persian Gulf to the Sea of Oman and vice versa. The traffic of commercial vessels will immediately start and, considering the needs for removing the technical and military obstacles and demining by the Islamic Republic of Iran, will be instated within 30 days. The Islamic Republic of Iran will conduct dialogue with the Sultanate of Oman to define the future administration and maritime services in the Strait of Hormuz in discussion	- with other Persian Gulf littoral states in line with the applicable international law and the sovereign rights of coastal states of the Strait of Hormuz. - The United States of America undertakes with regional partners to develop a definitive mutually agreed plan with at least USD 300 billion for the reconstruction and economic development of the Islamic Republic of Iran. The mechanism for the implementation of this plan will be finalized as part of a final deal within 60 days. All required licenses, waivers and permissions needed for the relevant financial transactions will be granted by the United States of America. - The United States of America undertakes to terminate all types of sanctions against the Islamic Republic of Iran, including the United Nations Security Council resolutions, IAEA Board of Governors resolutions and all unilateral U.S. sanctions, primary and secondary, in an agreed upon schedule as part of the final deal. The Islamic Republic of Iran and the United States of America acknowledge the critical importance of the sanctions termination issue above mentioned and express their intentions to immediately address these issues in the negotiations in order to achieve mutual agreement on them. - The Islamic Republic of Iran reaffirms that it shall not procure or develop nuclear weapons. United States of America and the Islamic Republic of Iran have agreed to resolve the disposition of stockpile enriched material pursuant to a mechanism that will be mutually agreed upon in accordance with the schedule mentioned in Paragraph 7 with the minimum methodology to be downblending on site under the supervision of the IAEA. The two parties also agreed to discuss the issue of enrichment and other mutually agreed matters related to the Islamic Republic of Iran’s nuclear needs, based on a satisfactory framework being agreed upon in the final deal. The final deal will confirm the provisions of this paragraph. The United States of America and the Islamic Republic of Iran acknowledge the critical importance of the nuclear issues above mentioned and express their intention
- to immediately address these issues in the negotiations in order to achieve mutual agreement on them. - Pending the final deal, the United States of America and the Islamic Republic of Iran agree to maintain the status quo. The Islamic Republic will maintain the current status quo of its nuclear program and the United States of America will not impose any new sanctions and will not deploy additional forces in the region. - The United States of America undertakes that immediately upon the signing of this MOU and until the termination of sanctions the U.S. Department of Treasury will issue waivers for the export of Iranian crude oil, petroleum products and derivatives and all associated services including banking transactions, insurances, transportation, etc. - The United States of America undertakes to make fully available for use the frozen or restricted funds and assets of the Islamic Republic of Iran upon the implementation of this MOU. The United States of America and the Islamic Republic of Iran will mutually agree on the procedures related to the release of these funds during the negotiations. Such funds, whether retained in the original account or transferred shall be made fully usable for payment to any ultimate beneficiary designated by the Central Bank of the Islamic Republic of Iran. The United States of America undertakes to issue all necessary licenses and authorizations accordingly. - The United States of America and the Islamic Republic of Iran agree that an executive mechanism will be established to monitor the successful implementation of this MOU and the future compliance of the final deal. - After signing this MOU and subject to the beginning of the implementation of paragraphs 1, 4, 5, 10 and 11 of this MOU, and the continuing implementation of these measures, the United States of America and the Islamic Republic of Iran will start negotiations regarding the final deal exclusively on the other paragraphs. - The final deal will be endorsed by binding UNSC resolution. (PNS)	

Europe explores energy security alternatives after Iran war’s turmoil

MENELAOS HADJICOSTIS ■ Nicosia

The Iran war’s shock to global fuel prices has reinforced Europe’s stance that it must forge alternative trade and energy routes to the Strait of Hormuz.

European Commission President Ursula von der Leyen has expressed renewed interest in what is known as the India-Middle-East-Europe Economic Corridor. She told G7 leaders at this week’s summit that “alternative export routes have been created that are more resilient and offer choices” while “other routes

will be built — for example, a typical one is IMEC.”

IMEC is seen as potentially offering the EU greater economic resilience, supply-chain diversification and energy security to bolster the bloc’s strategic autonomy at a time when Russia shows few signs of curbing its belligerence and the US chips away at strategic bonds. (AP)

Residents return to Southern Lebanon with hope and sorrow

KAREEM CHEHAYEB/ MALAK HARB ■ Tyre

Adnan Kaour returned on Thursday to check on his home in southern Lebanon’s coastal city of Tyre - once known as an idyllic summer getaway spot - just a week after Israel issued warnings for all of its residents to evacuate.

The warnings were followed by sweeping airstrikes on the city, which Israel said targeted the Lebanese Hezbollah militant group.

What Kaour found back in Tyre, shattered his hopes - his dream family apartment overlooking the shimmering Mediterranean Sea was a heap of rubble and shattered glass. His return coincided with the announce-



ment of an agreement between the United States and Iran to end the war in the Middle East. The deal also calls for an end to the war in Lebanon, where Israel has been fighting Hezbollah, but it’s unclear what that means

in practice.Israel and Hezbollah are not parties to the agreement. Iran insists Israel must withdraw from the large swath of southern Lebanon it is occupying, but the wording of the interim deal doesn’t explicitly require

ISRAELI TROOPS TO STAY LEBANON: NETANYAHU	
Tyre: Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu said on Thursday that Israel’s military will stay in southern Lebanon, where it has occupied up to 10 kilometres from the border. The remarks were his first comment since the US-Iran deal was signed. Netanyahu said Israel must “maintain a security zone in southern Lebanon, and it requires that we must not leave there as long as Israel’s	security needs require it.” He has made similar comments in the past about Israel’s refusal to withdraw from southern Lebanon. The US-Iran deal to end the war in the Middle East, signed overnight, also calls for an end to the war in Lebanon, where Israel has been fighting the militant Hezbollah group, but it’s unclear what that means in practice. (AP)

PUBLIC NOTICE
Notice is hereby given to the General Public on behalf of our client, ICEI Bank Ltd. that Mr. Rajiv Bhattacharya, Mr. Rahul Bhattacharya, & Mrs. Ritika Bhattacharya are claiming to be owners of Property Plot No. 28, Block-K, Area Measuring 192 Sq. Mtrs, Situated at Sector XI, NOIDA, vide a mutation Letter dated 14.05.2025 in the record of Noida Authority after demise of Mr. Devenendra Kumar Bhattacharya, & Mrs. Shashi Prabha Bhattacharya, All Persons are hereby informed that above claiming owners want to sale the said property to Mr. Jatin Singh Bala or his nominee who is taking a loan facility from our client for purchase the said property. If anybody has any objections upon the ownership of above claiming owners, its sale/mortgage, and any other kind of objection/litigation, Charge etc., kindly inform the undersigned in writing on the below mentioned address within 14 days of the present.
Kumar & Associates (Advocates & Consultants)
200, Indr Fir, 23, Shivaji Marg, Moti Nagar, N.Delhi-15
lsgo@kmalgoi.com Ph: 011-4115252-28

PUBLIC NOTICE
We, Mrs. Chanchal Rani Khullar and Mr. Jaswant Lal Khullar, hereby notify that our son, Mr. Amit Khullar along with his wife Mrs. Malika Khullar, stands disassociated from our personal, financial and property affairs with effect from 18th June 2026, as already intimated to them. They have no authority to deal with our assets and claim any properties in any manner whatsoever. Any person dealing with any of them on our behalf shall do so at his/her own risk and consequences.
Sd/- Mrs. Chanchal Rani Khullar
Sd/- Mr. Jaswant Lal Khullar
Dated: 18.06.2026.

PUBLIC NOTICE
General public is hereby informed that my client, Mr. Raees Ahmad, intends to purchase a portion of the immovable property measuring 70 Sq. yds. (out of a total area of 150 Sq. yds.) consisting of ground plus 3 floors, part of property bearing H.No. 17/17, Gali No. 15, Khasra No. 17-18, situated at Vijay Park, Majupur, Shahdara, Delhi - 110053. The current owner/occupant, Smt. Farha D/o Naeem Akhtar, claims absolute ownership and clear title over the said property primarily on the basis of a General Power of Attorney (GPA) and supporting chain documents. Any individual, bank, financial institution, government body, or authority having any claim, right, title, interest, objection, mortgage, lien, or charge over the said property or any part thereof is hereby requested to make the same known to the undersigned in writing, along with supporting documentary evidence, within 7 days from the date of publication of this notice. If no objections or claims are received within the stipulated period, it shall be deemed that the property is free from all encumbrances, and my client will proceed with the transaction. No claims or objections shall be entertained thereafter.
S.K. Chauhan (Advocate)
Delhi High Court, Mob.: 9311344434

PUBLIC NOTICE
To be known to all, PAWAN KUMAR SETHI S/O B.N.SETHI R/O 443, KHURBURA NEAR RISHI BHARAT, BUNDAL ROAD, DEHRADUN, UTTARAKHAND-248001. The original FDR issue by DDA in respect of Plot No. 508, Block - A, Pocket - 3, Sector-37, Rohini, Delhi. Vide file No.F-16/27513/2012/RHN premises has been lost/misplaced. An FIR to this effect has been lodged in the kotwali police station, Dehradun, Uttarakhand on 13/06/2018, may please contact at above address/mobile 9873077872 within 15 days from the date of publication of this notice. The person(s) claiming any right/interest can personally inform or write to Dy. Director(Lab) Rohini

CHANGE OF NAME
I, Parul D/O Premhari Sharma, R/O Sarakari Chowd, Ratan Garhi, Aligarh, U.P. - 202165, do hereby inform the general public that my correct name is PARUL. However, my name has been wrongly recorded as SADHANA KUMARI in my Aadhaar Card, and both names refer to one and the same person. Further, my correct Date of Birth is 20/09/2007, whereas it has been incorrectly mentioned as 01/01/2007 in my Aadhaar Card. Both dates belong to the same person. Hence, I request all concerned authorities and the general public to take note of the above corrections.



बैंक ऑफ बड़ोदा
Bank of Baroda



Branch Details: B1 Janakpuri
New Delhi-110058. Email:
JANAKP@bankofbaroda.bank.in

PUBLIC NOTICE
This is to inform the general public that Bank of Baroda, B1 Janakpuri Branch intends to accept the undermentioned property standing in the name of **M/s Neelam Finlease Pvt Ltd** Represented through its Director **Mr. Krishan Mohan Sharan & Mr. Ajit Mohan Sharan**, as security for a loan/credit facility requested by one of its customers.
In case anyone has got any right/title/interest/claims over the undermentioned property, they are advised to approach the Bank within 10 days along with necessary proof to substantiate their claim.
If no response is received within 10 days, it is presumed that the property is free of any charge/claim/encumbrance and Bank shall proceed with the mortgage.
Details of the property:- All the pieces and parcel of Property bearing Plot No-22, Block-A, Greenwood's city, Sector-45, Gurgaon, Haryana-122003 in the name of M/s Neelam Finlease Pvt Ltd.
Boundaries of Property:
South East: Plot No. A-21, North East: Road
South West: Plot No. 5, North West: Plot No. A-23
Branch Details: B1 Janakpuri New Delhi-110058. Email: JANAKP@bankofbaroda.bank.in

PUBLIC NOTICE
This is to inform that Ace Group has not launched any new project at any location other than those listed on our official website, www.acegroupindia.com. Further, Ace Group has not authorized any channel partner, broker, or third party to promote or advertise any project that is not listed on our official website. It has come to our notice that certain advertisements and promotions are being circulated on various digital and social media platforms regarding new projects in Noida and along the Yamuna Expressway under the name of Ace Group. We hereby clarify that such promotions are false, unauthorized, and have no association whatsoever with Ace Group. Ace Group shall not be liable or responsible for any claims, representations, commitments, or information made through such unauthorized promotions. Members of the public are advised to verify all project-related information only through our official website, www.acegroupindia.com.

Thanks,
Team Ace Group

CHANGE OF NAME
I, Mohammad Nasir, S/o. Sabir Khan, R/o. K-96, 4th floor, Thokar No. 5, Abul Fazal Enclave-I, Jamia Nagar, New Delhi-110025, have changed my name from Mohammad Nasir to Nasir Khan for all future purposes.
PD(1407)C
I, No.14844175A Hav/MT Vinod Kumar, R/o- Vill- Birnwash, PO- Ujfoli, Teh- Kotkasim, Dist- Alwar, Rajasthan- 301702, have changed my son's name from Mayank to Mayank Sharma, vide affidavit dated 18/06/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.
PD(1408)C
I, Mamta Kumari, W/o- No.3204810M Hav Lokesh Kumar, R/o- Vill- Sanjaynagar, PO- Bhojasar, Teh&Dist- Jhunjhun, Rajasthan, declare that in my Husband's service record my name is wrongly recorded as Mamta, whereas my correct name is Mamta Kumari, which may be amended accordingly.
PD(1409)C

I, Nageshwar Pandit, Father of No.14862423N Hav/MT Subodh Kumar Pandit, R/o- Vill & PO- Jahangir Pur Sham, Dist- Vaishali, Bihar, 844504, in my son's service records my D.O.B is wrongly written as 06/05/1965 whereas my correct D.O.B is 01/01/1947 which may be amended accordingly.
PD(1410)C
I, No.16013065P Hav Shiv Mangal Singh, R/o- VPO- Chandwara, Dist- Banda, U.P.- 210126, have changed my daughter's name from Kumari Khushi to Khushi Singh, vide dated 18/06/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.
PD(1411)C
I, No. 14830872P Hav/MT Jahenda Singh Baghel, R/o- Vill & PO- Chiruli, Teh- Dabra, Dist- Gwalior, Madhya Pradesh- 475005, have changed my son's name from Shourabh Singh Baghel to Saurabh Singh Baghel, vide affidavit dated 18/06/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.
PD(1412)C
I, Gomati, Mother of No.16013065P Hav Shiv Mangal Singh, R/o- VPO- Chandwara, Dist- Banda, U.P.- 210126, have changed my name from Gomati to Gomti, vide dated 18/06/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.
PD(1413)C

I, hitherto known as Jaspreet Singh S/O- Darshan Singh Deygun, R/o- WZ-123, Gali No. 7, Lajwanti Garden, South West Delhi, Delhi- 110046, have changed my name and shall hereafter be known as Jaspreet Singh Devgun.
PD(1414)C
I, Indra Devi W/o No.16013065P Hav Shiv Mangal Singh, R/o- VPO- Chandwara, Dist- Banda, U.P.- 210126, have changed my name from Indra Devi to Indra Singh, vide dated 18/06/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.
PD(1415)C
I, Shylaja Kumari P, Mother of- No.23004466X Sep Akshay RS, R/o- Shylaja Bhavan, Pulichamala, Parappara, P.O- Tholicoode, Thiruvananthapuram, Kerala- 695551, declare that in my son's service record my D.O.B is wrongly mentioned as 22/08/1970 whereas my correct DOB is 01/01/1974 which may be amended accordingly.
PD(1416)C
I, Sumitra Devi, Mother of No.14862423N Hav/MT Subodh Kumar Pandit, R/o- Vill & PO- Jahangir Pur Sham, Dist- Vaishali, Bihar, 844504, in my son's service records my D.O.B is wrongly written as 17/04/1968 whereas my correct D.O.B is 01/01/1958 which may be amended accordingly.
PD(1417)C



बैंक ऑफ बड़ोदा
Bank of Baroda



Branch Details: B1 Janakpuri
New Delhi-110058. Email:
JANAKP@bankofbaroda.bank.in

PUBLIC NOTICE
This is to inform the general public that Bank of Baroda, B1 Janakpuri Branch intends to accept the undermentioned property standing in the name of **M/S. Cordial Technologies Pvt Ltd** (Represented through its Director **Mr. Anil Mohan Sharan**, as security for a loan/credit facility requested by one of its customers.
In case anyone has got any right/title/interests/claims over the undermentioned property, they are advised to approach the Bank within 10 days along with necessary proof to substantiate their claim.
If no response is received within 10 days, it is presumed that the property is free of any charge/claim/encumbrance and Bank shall proceed with the mortgage.
Details of the property:- All the pieces and parcel of Property comprising of Industrial Plot (alongwith construction thereon) No. 495-496, measuring 900 Sq Meters, situated in Sector-08, IMT Manesar, Distt. Gurugram (Haryana), in the name of **M/S. Cordial Technologies Pvt Ltd** (Represented through its Director **Mr. Anil Mohan Sharan** Boundaries of Property: North: No. 494, East: Road, South: No. 497, West: No. 509-510
Branch Details: B1 Janakpuri New Delhi-110058. Email: JANAKP@bankofbaroda.bank.in



आगरा कॉलेज, आगरा

स्थायी रिक्त पदों हेतु विज्ञापन (विज्ञापन संख्या सं० AGC/02/2025-26)
आगरा कॉलेज, आगरा में निम्नांकित स्थायी रिक्त पदों के लिये पृथक्-पृथक् आवेदन पत्र आमंत्रित किये जाते हैं:-
(क) स्तुतीय श्रेणी लैब तकनीशियन, गौरीकी विमान-01 पद
पद का नाम श्रेणी संख्या वेतनमान शैक्षणिक अर्हता
लैब अनारक्षित 01 5200-20200, ग्रेड पे-2000, लेवल-03 संबंधित विषय के साथ मातृता प्राप्त संख्या से स्नातक परीक्षा उत्तीर्णी हो तथा कम्यूटर संचालन का डायक (DOEACC) सोसाइटी परिवर्तित नाम न्यूलेट (NIELT) द्वारा प्रदत्त सीरीजीसी प्रमाणपत्र/ समकक्ष स्तर का प्रमाण-पत्र
(ख) चतुर्थ श्रेणी विद्युत निस्त्री-कुल 02 पद
पद का नाम श्रेणी संख्या वेतनमान शैक्षणिक अर्हता
विद्युत निस्त्री 01 आरक्षित-एचएचएच 01 आरक्षित-ओपीसीसी 02 5200-20200, ग्रेड पे-1900, लेवल-02 1. डाई स्कूल (10वीं) उत्तीर्ण तथा 2. मातृता प्राप्त औद्योगिक प्रशिक्षण संस्थान (ITI) से Electrician Trade प्रमाणपत्र

नोट:- उक्त सभी पदों हेतु 01 जुलाई 2025 को आवेदन की न्यूनतम आयु 18 वर्ष तथा अधिकतम आयु 40 वर्ष होनी चाहिये। अन्यथाओं को अधिकतम आयु सीमा में उत्तर-प्रदेश सरकार के शासनवशांनुसार घूट प्रदान की जायेगी।
आवेदन पत्र आगरा कॉलेज, आगरा की वेबसाइट www.agracollegeagra.org.in से डाउनलोड कर समस्त स्वमागणित सलन्मको सहित हो प्रतियों में तथा निश्चित कुल शुल्क रु० 1180 (रु० 1000 शुल्क तथा जीएएसटी० रु० 118) प्राचार्य, आगरा कॉलेज, आगरा के नाम से बैंक ड्राफ्ट अथवा नेफ्ट द्वारा ऑनलाइन भुगतान (खाता सं० 2481201005001, केनरा बैंक, राजा की मंडी, आगरा, IFSC Code- CNR80002481) करने के बाद बैंक द्वारा भुगतान की प्रमाणित प्रति सहित केवल स्पीड पोस्ट के माध्यम से प्राचार्य, आगरा कॉलेज, एमएचजीरोड, आगरा-282002 को दिनांक 07.07.2026 तक प्रदान होंगें। इसके उपरान्त प्राप्त आवेदन पत्रों पर विचार नहीं किया जायेगा। रिक्त पदों की संख्या में नियमानुसार परिवर्तन हो सकता है। रिक्त पदों के सापेक्ष अधिक संख्या में आवेदन प्राप्त होने की स्थिति में साक्षात्कार से पूर्व स्वीयिंग परीक्षा की कराई जा सकती है।
प्राचार्य/ सचिव, प्रबन्ध समिति, आगरा कॉलेज, आगरा पिनकोड 282002

Property Address of Secured Assets: All that piece and parcel of Plot No. 50 Ground and Second Floor Free Hold Built Up Two and Half Storey Property Measuring 29 Sq. Mtrs. Situated at Sector - 3, (Karuna Kunj), Dwarka Residential Scheme, Dwarka, New Delhi - 110076 and bounded as under - East : As per Title Deed, West : As per Title Deed, North : As per Title Deed, South : As per Title Deed

In the circumstances as aforesaid, the notice is hereby given to the above borrowers, co-borrowers and guarantors (where ever applicable) to pay the outstanding dues mentioned above along with future interest and applicable charges within 60 days from the date of the publication of this notice failing which further steps will be taken after the expiry of 60 days of the date of this notice against the secured assets including taking possession of the secured assets of the borrowers and the mortgagors under Section 13(4) of Securitisation of Assets Act, 2002 and/or other legal remedies available to the lender under the law and the applicable rules thereunder. Kind attention is invited to provisions of sub-section (8) of Section 13 of the SARFAESI Act where under you can tender the entire amount of outstanding dues together with all costs, charges and expenses incurred by the Bank only till the date of publication of the notice for sale of the secured asset(s) by public auction, by inviting quotations or tenders from public or by private treaty, you may not be entitled to redeem the secured asset(s). Please note that under Section 13 (13) of the said Act, no Borrower or Guarantor shall be permitted to tender any sum towards redemption of the secured assets if he has secured assets referred to in the notice, without prior written consent of the secured creditor.

Dated; 19.06.2026. Place: NOIDA U.P. Sd/- Authorized Officer Axis Bank Ltd

Assam CM Himanta reviews NEET-UG 2026 re-exam preparedness, stresses fair conduct

TONY DAS ■ Guwahati

With the NEET-UG 2026 re-examination scheduled for June 21, Assam Chief Minister Dr Himanta Biswa Sarma on Tuesday reviewed the preparedness of districts where the examination will be conducted and directed officials to ensure robust security measures for its free, fair and transparent conduct.

The review meeting was held through video conference and attended by District Commissioners, Senior Superintendents of Police (SSPs) and other senior district officials.

According to officials, a total of 43,319 candidates have registered for the re-examination across Assam. The test will be conducted at 87 examination centres spread across 17 districts of the state.

During the meeting, the Chief Minister instructed District Commissioners and SSPs to jointly inspect all examination centres to assess security arrangements, infrastruc-



ture readiness and logistical preparations. He also directed authorities to conduct mandatory technical audits and dry runs of CCTV cameras, biometric devices and signal jammers well before the examination date.

To strengthen security around examination venues, Dr Sarma ordered the enforcement of prohibitory measures within a 100-metre radius of all centres. He stressed the need for adequate public awareness campaigns to inform people about the restrictions and ensure that only candidates are allowed near the examination premis-

es. The Chief Minister also directed the deployment of sufficient women police personnel at all centres.

Highlighting the importance of maintaining examination integrity, Dr Sarma called for strict adherence to National Testing Agency (NTA) guidelines on candidate frisking. He instructed officials to carry out double-layer frisking in a professional and courteous manner while maintaining maximum vigilance against any attempt at malpractice.

The Chief Minister further directed that a nodal officer be appointed in every district for CCTV monitoring and that

random checks of CCTV footage be conducted regularly. Regarding the security of question papers, he ordered strict regulation of access to bank lockers where question papers are stored. Visits by private individuals, he said, should be permitted only under exceptional circumstances and with prior approval from the District Magistrate. Additionally, a senior police officer not below the rank of Deputy Superintendent of Police (DSP) will be designated in each district to oversee the security and monitoring of the lockers.

Officials informed the meeting that a dedicated control room will be established at the office of the Director of Medical Education and will become operational from June 19. To facilitate candidates' travel on the examination day, free transportation on Assam State Transport Corporation (ASTC) buses will be provided upon presentation of valid admit cards.

Bharti Airtel's Rahul Vatts named COAI Chairperson

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Rahul Vatts, the Group Chief Regulatory Officer and Director, Corporate Affairs of Bharti Airtel, was named the new Chairperson of COAI, as the telecom industry association announced its leadership for 2026-27 on Thursday.

Vatts takes over at the helm of COAI from Vodafone Idea's Abhijit Kishore who served as Chairperson of the telcos' body for 2025-26.

Further, Ravi Gandhi, Chief Regulatory Officer of Reliance Jio Infocomm, will serve as Vice-Chairperson of COAI, the release said.

Announcing the conclusion of its Annual General Body Meeting for the 2025-26 fiscal year, COAI said the meeting brought together members to review key developments in the sector, deliberate on emerging priorities and discuss the roadmap for strengthening India's digital communications ecosystem.

"The COAI leadership for



2026-27 was also announced at the meeting. Rahul Vatts, Group Chief Regulatory Officer and Director, Corporate Affairs, Bharti Airtel Limited, will serve as Chairperson of COAI, while Ravi P Gandhi, Chief Regulatory Officer, Reliance Jio Infocomm will serve as Vice-Chairperson,"the COAI release said.

Vatts is a telecom industry veteran with 29 years of experience across telecom and broadcasting licensing, economic regulation, spectrum management and regulatory litigation.

As Chief Regulatory Officer of Bharti Airtel, he leads the company's government relations, policy and regulatory engagements across mobility, broadband, DTH, data centres, submarine cables, international subsidiaries and digital businesses, COAI said adding he also chairs GSMA's Spectrum Policy Working Group and is a member of GSMA's Global Policy Group and Spectrum Strategy and Management Group.

Gandhi brings over three decades of experience in public policy, telecom reg-

ulation and network operations, and has previously served as Chief Regulatory Officer at Bharti Airtel and, as an officer of the Indian Telecom Services, held key positions in the Department of Telecommunications, Government of India.

"He exemplifies the powerful combination of technical expertise and strategic foresight, driving innovation and meaningful societal impact,"the release said, adding that Gandhi holds a PhD from IIT Delhi and a BTech from NIT Kurukshetra.

COAI Director General SP Kochhar noted that India's telecom sector is at a critical stage of transformation, with digital communications infrastructure increasingly serving as the foundation of the country's digital economy.

"As technologies such as AI, 5G Advanced, satellite communications and future 6G systems evolve, the sector will play an even greater role in enabling innovation, inclusion and economic growth,"Kochhar added.

PROSPECT State Bank of India to raise ₹60,000 cr in FY27 via bonds



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

State Bank of India (SBI) on Thursday said its board has approved a proposal to raise up to ₹60,000 crore in the current fiscal through the issue of debt instruments.

The funds would be raised either in rupee and/or any other convertible currency by issue of debt instruments like long-term

bonds, Basel III-compliant Additional Tier 1 Bonds and Basel III compliant Tier 2 Bonds.

The funds would be raised through public offer or private placement mode to Indian and/or overseas investors during FY27, SBI said in a regulatory filing.

Shares of SBI were trading at ₹1,040.25, up 1.39 per cent over previous close on BSE.

India could save ₹28,540 cr through anti-dumping duties: C-DEP report

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Timely implementation of pending anti-dumping duty recommendations could help India save nearly ₹28,540 crore annually in foreign exchange, support domestic investments worth around ₹70,000 crore and strengthen the country's manufacturing base, according to a new report by the Centre for Domestic and Economic Policy (C-DEP). The report argues that anti-dumping duties should be viewed not merely as protective measures but as instruments for ensuring fair competition and fostering long-term industrial growth.

The report, titled 'Impact of Anti-Dumping Duties in India' highlights that the Directorate General of Trade Remedies (DGTR) has recommended anti-dumping duties on 56 product categories that are yet to be implemented.

According to the study the delay in enforcing these recommendations has resulted in an estimated annual eco-



nomical loss of ₹11,938 crore to Indian industry.

The report states that implementation of the pending measures would reduce dependence on imports and create opportunities for expanding domestic manufacturing capabilities. It adds that such action would help create a more balanced and sustainable industrial ecosystem by enabling Indian producers to compete on fair terms.

The findings assume significance at a time when India is aggressively expanding manufacturing capacity across key sectors, including steel, infrastructure, railways,

defence and renewable energy. The report notes that a stable and equitable trade environment is essential for sustaining long-term growth and attracting investments into these sectors.

According to C-DEP, anti-dumping duties play a critical role in addressing unfair trade practices and ensuring a level playing field for domestic manufacturers. The report particularly underscores the importance of these measures for micro, small and medium enterprises (MSMEs) which often struggle to compete against imported goods sold at artificially low prices.

NEIINFRA 2026 concludes in Shillong, showcases Northeast growth vision

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The North East India Infrastructure Summit & Exhibition 2026 (NEIINFRA) concluded in Shillong on Tuesday, bringing together industry leaders and investors to discuss infrastructure and sustainable growth opportunities across the Northeast. The two-day event highlighted the region's growing importance as a hub for connectivity, trade, tourism and entrepreneurship.

Hosted by the Government of Meghalaya and organised by the Federation of Industry & Commerce of the North Eastern Region (FINER) in collaboration with the Build India Foundation, the summit focused on strengthening partnerships and accelerating development in the region.

Addressing the session, Union Minister for Culture and Tourism, Gajendra Singh Shekhawat outlined a vision of transforming the Northeast into a gateway to Southeast Asia. He said infrastructure development was about connecting people to opportunities, services and markets,



NHA Advisor Vaibhav Dange felicitates Nagaland Deputy Chief Minister TR Zeliang during NEIINFRA 2026 in Shillong

PIONEER PHOTO

noting that more than ₹6 lakh crore had been invested in the region since 2014 across highways, railways, airports, waterways, digital networks and energy projects. He also stressed the importance of climate resilient development, environmental conservation and youth-led entrepreneurship.

Pradyot Bikram Manikya Deb Barman; Chairman of TIPRA Motha, emphasised that tourism should directly benefit local communities by generating jobs and income while preserving indigenous culture and the environment. He also called for improved air connectivity and cargo infrastructure to unlock economic opportunities.

TR Zeliang; Deputy Chief Minister of Nagaland, highlighted the importance of strengthening regional connectivity and infrastructure to unlock the Northeast's economic potential and accelerate inclusive development across the region.

Key sessions explored tourism, industrial development, MSMEs, startups, renewable energy and infrastructure modernisation. Discussions on tourism focused on eco-tourism, heritage conservation and community-led initiatives, while a dedicated session on MSMEs and startups examined innovative funding mechanisms, incubation support and access to capital.

Yoga Day preparations reviewed in Kamrup ahead of district-level celebration

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Amingaon

Preparations for the observance of the 12th International Day of Yoga in Kamrup district were reviewed at a meeting held at the Conference Hall of the Integrated District Commissioner's Office in Amingaon on Wednesday.

The meeting was chaired by District Commissioner Deba Kumar Mishra, who assessed the arrangements being made for the district-level celebration scheduled to be held on June 21, 2026, at Gandhi Ashram in Sualkuchi. The programme will begin at 6.00 am and will be attended by the Governor of Assam, Shri Lakshman Prasad Subhasish Baruah, Chief Executive Officer of the Zila Parishad Siddhartha Goswami, District Development Commissioner Susanta Kumar Dutta, Additional District



The District Commissioner emphasised the need for close coordination among all departments and stakeholders involved in the programme and urged them to extend full cooperation for its successful observance.

Among those present at the meeting were Senior Superintendent of Police Subhasish Baruah, Chief Executive Officer of the Zila Parishad Siddhartha Goswami, District Development Commissioner Susanta Kumar Dutta, Additional District

Commissioners, Heads of Departments, and representatives of Gandhi Ashram, Sualkuchi.

The International Day of Yoga is observed annually on June 21 to promote the benefits of yoga and encourage healthy living. The district administration is making comprehensive preparations to ensure the successful celebration of the occasion in Kamrup.

D Show sets benchmark for India's diamond trade

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The International Gemological Institute (IGI) has once again raised the bar for India's diamond and jewellery industry with the successful conclusion of the 23rd edition of its flagship IGI D Show. The three-day event was held from June 11 to 13, under the evocative theme "Blueprint of Brilliance."

Cementing its stature as one of the most influential buyer-seller meets in the country, the show brought together 45 diamond manufacturers and more than 180 retailers from across India under one roof, creating a vibrant, high-energy marketplace designed for serious business and meaningful growth.

Government of Assam Skill, Employment & Entrepreneurship Department Block-D, 1st Floor, Janata Bhawan, Dispur, Guwahati-6 Application for Vice Chancellor. Assam Skill University

Applications/ nominations are sought for to fill the post of Vice Chancellor of Assam Skill University, Mangaldai. The interested candidates who are eligible, as per UGC norms may arrange to send their applications/ nominations in the prescribed format which is available on the department website (skill.assam.gov.in) and university website (www.asu.ac.in) along with other details. Both the hard copy and the soft copy of the applications/nominations of prospective candidates must reach on or before, 18th July, 2026 at 5.00 P.M. at the following address:

Shri Akash Deep, IAS
Commissioner & Secretary to the Govt, of Assam, Skill, Employment& Entrepreneurship Department Block -1, 3rdFloor, Janata Bhawan, Dispur,Guwahati-6
Email ID- vc.recruitment.asu@gmail.com

Applicants should not be more than 65 years of age as on the closing date for receipt of applications.

Sd/-Commissioner & Secretary to the Govt, of Assam. DIPR/D/PIO/100/19-Jun-26

DAILY SUDOKU

6			2		8
		7	5	2	9
			6		1
1	6	3			5
2					3
				6	1
1	7		4		
	8	2	9	7	
6		5			4

DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★★★★☆

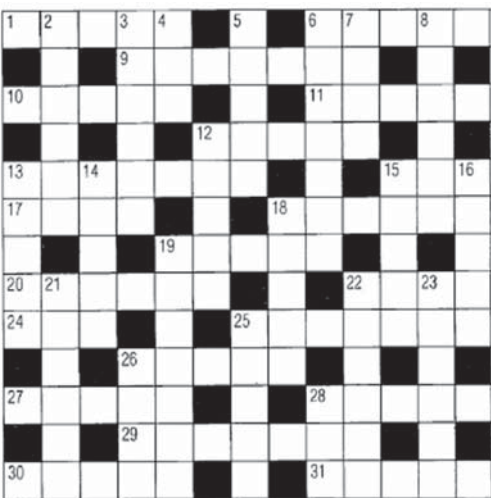
HOW TO SOLVE IT

Sudoku is a logic puzzle where you fill a 9x9 grid so that numbers 1 to 9 appear once in every row, column, and 3x3 box, using elimination and logical deduction-maths involved.



SOLUTION (18.6.26)								
7	8	9	5	1	3	2	4	6
5	2	3	8	4	6	9	1	7
6	4	1	9	2	7	8	5	3
8	5	2	3	7	1	6	9	4
1	6	7	4	5	9	3	8	2
3	9	4	6	8	2	1	7	5
4	3	5	1	6	8	7	2	9
2	1	6	7	9	5	4	3	8
9	7	8	2	3	4	5	6	1

DOUBLE CROSSWORD FRIDAY | JUNE 19, 2026



ACROSS

- The woman for many a man (5)
- She's a nut! (5)
- Finding the illuminations intoxicating? (3,2)
- Get a hundred advanced by deceit (3)
- Running tracks! (5)
- Dear me, shaken by the idealist's rousing start! (7)
- Gave one's playmates a hand (5)
- Container of cabbages? (3)
- A fairly normal district (6)
- Loose and fluttering - free as a bird? (7)
- Where to find some Irish heiresses (4)

DOWN

- Lustrous greyish wild crane (5)
- Suitable for holding (7)
- How can a door be this? (4)
- It's a long time for one to dally foolishly (3,3)
- His meanness upsets me sir (5)
- Targeted speculators? (5)
- She's like Joe, but not very pronouncedly (3)
- Sumptuously entertains a chap with drinks (7)
- She's a blossom (3)
- Meant to get me to help out (5)
- Unit of the Royal Marines (5)

- Behind, due to a rare mix-up! (4)
- Was worth making me tired (7)
- Three good contests (6)
- Adversary of an RAF officer at a loose end (3)
- A biblical character made her do wrong (5)
- This vessel can possibly be in wood (7)
- Copy the figures (5)
- Great little flier, maybe (3)
- To overreact seemed not quite nice to dad (5)
- Not above breaking an elbow (5)
- Was able to make a good rhyme (5)

- Certainly not the Ocean of Storms! (7)
- Sound way to use a balance (5)
- For him, the right share's a long way out! (5)
- Go in for unoriginality? (2-5)
- Doc could be a bit of a comedian! (6)
- Not up to weight! (3)
- That royal quality about a girl! (5)
- House with tailless mice? That's funny! (5)
- In part, he'll do (5)
- Medicine that makes you sick on the quiet? (4)
- To feel unwell upsets Ali (3)

SOLUTION (18.6.26)

ACROSS		DOWN	
1, Pixie	19, Dixie	2, Rd-ling	15, Hiram
6, St-ubs	20, Heston	16, E-NT-er	16, E-NT-er
9, Slender	22, Base	3, I-so-bar	18, Aisle
10, B-L-oom	24, Tr-e	4, Elm	19, Don-a-Ted
11, Rum-my	25, Bloomer	5, Unwed	21, Eighty
12, Serve	26, Mar-i-e	6, Service	22, B-ovine
13, Engaged	27, Sh-Q-ut	7, True	23, Sell up
15, Hoe	28, Title	8, Bamboo	25, Billy
17, Igor	29, Sea lion	9, Muse	26, Muse
18, Action	30, Dyfed	13, Eight	28, Top
	31, Peeps	14, Go-ose	

BRIEFLY

Croatia's Petar Musa scores despite loss to England



Croatian striker Petar Musa has more experience scoring goals in the Dallas area than even the biggest stars of this World Cup. He now has his first on soccer's biggest stage. The Dallas player became the third from Major League Soccer to score for a European team in World Cup, getting a tying goal on the final play before the whistle ending the first half of Croatia's 4-2 loss to England on Wednesday.

"The feeling was incredible to score a goal here at home, but I'm not happy because we lost the game," Musa said. "There's not much to celebrate because we lost the game."

Musa scored his 32nd goal in the Dallas area across all competitions. Playing for Dallas, the 28-year-old is tied with Argentina superstar Lionel Messi of Inter Miami for second in MLS with 12 goals this season. Musa has 46 in his three-year career in the U.S. league.

Switzerland says it can handle pressure in World Cup



Switzerland is already behind schedule just one game into the World Cup. Coach Murat Yakin says his team still has plenty of time to get where it wants to go.

The Swiss realise they're under pressure when they take on overachieving Bosnia-Herzegovina on Thursday at SoFi Stadium in both teams' second match of group-stage play.

No. 19 Switzerland is widely favoured to advance as the highest-ranked and most accomplished team in its group, but Die Nati shockingly blew its opening match in Northern California last weekend. Qatar salvaged a 1-1 draw by scoring in the fourth minute of second-half extra time.

Qatar fans get Government funded trip to the World Cup



Qatar brought a cheering section to the World Cup by treating a large contingent of supporters to an all-expenses-paid trip to North America. Some 1,000 Qatari fans have descended on Vancouver, via jets chartered by the Emir of Qatar, Sheikh Tamim bin Hamad Al Thani, ahead of Thursday's match against Canada. The fans are staying at posh hotels, including the Fairmont and the JW Marriott Parq. They've been turning heads downtown, breaking out traditional darbuka drums.

"First of all I would like to thank everyone who went the extra mile and made the journey out here," captain Abdulaziz Hatem said.

Minakshi moves to quarters of Boxing World Cup 2026 in China

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Guiyang (China)

Indian boxer Minakshi advanced to the quarterfinals of World Cup (Stage 2) in the women's 51kg category here on Thursday. Minakshi, the reigning 48kg world champion and current World No. 1 in that division, is transitioning into the Olympic 51kg weight class in the ongoing event.

She registered a convincing 5-0 unanimous decision victory over Poland's Natalia Kuczweska to move ahead in the competition.

In the other contest on day four, Abhinash Jamwal (65kg) bowed out after suffering a 0-5 defeat to



Kyrgyzstan's Mirzokhid Imamnazarov.

So far in the tournament, five Indian boxers have advanced to the quarterfinals. Nikhil (55kg), Deepak (70kg), Minakshi (51kg), Prachi (57kg), and Saneh (65kg).

Meanwhile, Jyoti (48kg) and Jugnoo (85kg) have already assured medals for the country by progressing into the semi-finals.

Four Indian boxers will take the ring in their quarter-final bouts.



From competitors to contenders: The redefinition of Indian women's cricket

SHAKYA MITRA

India have made a strong start to their campaign in the Women's T20 World Cup being played in England beating Pakistan and Netherlands in their first two games. As the reigning world champions (albeit in 50 over cricket), this tournament carries a unique significance for the women's cricket fraternity and fans, the status of entering a tournament with the tag of world champions.

For years, the Indian women's team carried the tag of being the nearly women of international cricket. They produced memorable campaigns and reached the semifinals and finals numerous times but could not cross the final hurdle. That narrative changed dramatically when Harmanpreet Kaur's side lifted the ODI World Cup on home soil in 2025.

That is why the T20 World Cup feels different. India are no longer challengers hoping to break through. They are now one of the teams everyone expects to contend for the title.

India have largely the same core group of players that won the ODI World Cup. Despite the demands of T20 cricket being different from ODIs, the confidence generated by winning a World Cup together cannot be underestimated.

India though find



themselves in a tough group alongside six-time World T20 champions Australia and South Africa whom they are still to play, two of the strongest sides in women's cricket. With only two teams progressing to the knockout stage, India cannot afford a league phase reminiscent of the ODI World Cup where they lost to each of the other three semifinalists.

Australia remain the benchmark despite entering a period of transition. The retirement of legendary captain Meg Lanning under whom Australia won 4 T20 World Cupssignalled the end of one era, while the departure of Alyssa Healy has further altered the complexion of the side. Yet writing them off would not be a wise idea. They will still be amongst the tournament favourites.

South Africa present a different challenge. Over the last few years they have established themselves as one of the most consistent teams in the women's game. Athletic in the field, disciplined with the ball and increasingly dangerous with the bat, they are more than capable of beating any side on their day.

Even if India emerge from this group, the route ahead remains challenging. A likely semifinal could pit them against the hosts England, New Zealand or West Indies (depend-

ing on qualification), formidable opponents with extensive experience in major tournaments.

Yet there are reasons for optimism. Indian players are no strangers to English conditions. Several members of the squad have featured in The Hundred, gaining valuable exposure to local pitches and weather conditions. Such familiarity could prove invaluable in a tournament where fine margins often determine outcomes.

England also evokes memories of both heartbreak and opportunity for Indian women's cricket. It was on English soil in 2017 that India came agonisingly close to winning the ODI World Cup. They were in a commanding position during the final against England before a dramatic batting collapse denied them a historic triumph.

The scars of near misses extend to the T20 format as well. During the 2023 T20 World Cup semifinal against Australia, India appeared well placed in the chase before a freak run-out involving Harmanpreet Kaur changed the course of the match. Such moments reinforced the perception that India lacked the ability to finish the job on the biggest stage.

The ODI World Cup victory has finally shattered that perception.

It has also transformed the landscape of women's cricket in India. Interest levels have soared, players have become largely familiar names and

there are higher expectations from the public. Success inevitably changes the standards by which teams are judged. Mere participation or reaching the semifinals or finals is not enough, winning will be the benchmark with which India will be judged.

No individual embodies that pressure more than Harmanpreet Kaur. The captain has already secured her place among the most influential figures in Indian women's cricket history, but she will be eager to build on that legacy. At the same time, she remains a figure who attracts scrutiny, with questions often raised about her form, long-term future and whether India should begin planning for a new leadership era. A successful T20 World Cup campaign would further cement Harmanpreet's standing as one of the defining figures of Indian women's cricket.

There is a much higher level of expectation that India carries with this T20 World Cup. A win will establish us as the new force in the women's game with success across format. An unsuccessful campaign will inevitably raise questions if the ODI World Cup was a one-off achievement.

That is the burden and privilege of becoming champions. India have spent years chasing history. Now they must prove they can live with it.

Smriti always tells me to stay calm on field: Shafali Verma

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Leeds

Indian women's cricket team opener Shafali Verma says greater mind control has been the key to her revival from a recent poor run and credited vice-captain Smriti Mandhana for helping her stay calm at the crease during the ongoing T20 World Cup here. Chasing their maiden women's T20 World Cup title, India have made a robust start with a 64-run victory over arch rivals Pakistan and a 95-run hammering of the Netherlands to top Group A with four points and a Net Run Rate of 3.975.

Against the Dutch side on Wednesday, Shafali made a 38-ball 55 to announce a welcome return to form. She and Mandhana combined to put on a 115-run stand in India's massive total of 209/5 against the Netherlands.

"We could not get the partnerships against England (in bilateral series) earlier. But we were talking a lot, helping each other on how we can build more partnerships," Shafali said referring to a bilateral assignment



before the World Cup.

"We played very well in the last match and after that I worked a lot in the nets. I tried to play along the ground, tried to control myself mentally, and we had a very good partnership," she added. The hard-hitting opener said she does not need to give a lot of inputs to Mandhana while batting. "I do not have to say much, she is very matured. But she keeps telling me — because I feel like hitting a six every time — she is the one who always tells me to stay calm, that you will get the ball and you have to play along the ground," Shafali said.

India beat Uruguay 3-2 to top pool in FIH Women's Nations Cup in Auckland



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Auckland

India bounced back after conceding an early goal to beat Uruguay 3-2 and finish at the top of Pool A in the FIH Women's Nations Cup New Zealand, here on Thursday.

Deepika netted twice while Deepika Soreng found the back of the net once as India recorded a third consecutive victory in the tournament, having earlier defeated USA and Japan.

USA finished second and joined India in the semifinals. India are

set to take on the winner of the contest between Chile or Korea on June 20 in the semifinal.

In the 13th minute of the contest, India were put on the backfoot after Chiara Appennino converted a penalty corner to put Uruguay ahead in the contest.

But India did not have to wait long for an equaliser as drag-flicker Deepika successfully converted a penalty corner in the 24th minute to make it 1-1.

Soreng then turned the momentum completely towards India, putting them ahead 2-1,

when she produced a fine field goal in the 43rd minute of the contest heading into the final quarter.

Uruguay found an equaliser through their skipper Manuela Vilar, who struck in the 55th minute but their joy was short lived as Deepika scored her second goal of the contest in the next minute to seal India's victory.

The contest also marked a memorable moment for Neha who completed her 200th appearance for India.

South Africa wants to appeal Themba Zwane's World Cup ban

JAMES ROBSON ■ Atlanta

South Africa coach Hugo Broos wants to appeal midfielder Themba Zwane's three-match ban for a red card at the World Cup, citing Lionel Messi in his reasoning. Zwane was given one of the three red cards in the opening game of the World Cup on Thursday, when Mexico beat South Africa 2-0. Broos noted Messi avoided punishment for what appeared to be a foul in Argentina's 3-0 win over Algeria on Tuesday as evidence of what he believes was unfair sanction by FIFA disciplinary committee.

Zwane was sent off in the 84th minute in Mexico City for hitting Roberto



Alvarado in the face. Standard punishment is a one-match suspension, but FIFA said Wednesday it had increased the sanction because it was deemed serious foul play.

The suspension means Zwane would not be able to play again until the round of

16 if South Africa advances that far. "I think the, the red card, is too severe. I saw back the situation where Themba got the red card. I don't think it was a red card," Broos said. "When I see what happened yesterday with Messi, then I don't agree."

Colombia's Luis stars in World Cup debut against Uzbekistan

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Mexico City

After contributing a goal and an assist in his World Cup debut, Colombia's Luis Diaz walked to the sidelines to look for his father. They spotted each other, fulfilling a dream that was years in the making. "A lot of things came to me from the past," Diaz said after Colombia beat Uzbekistan 3-1 on Wednesday. "I worked for this. I fought to be here."

First, Colombia failed to qualify for the 2022 World Cup. Then his parents were kidnapped. In late 2023, Luis Manuel "Mane" Diaz and his wife, Cilenis Marulanda, were captured by armed guerillas at the Colombia-Venezuela border. Marulanda was



quickly rescued, but Mane Diaz was not.

Luis Diaz, playing for Liverpool at the time, missed two games to return home to Barrancas and advocate for his father's freedom. Upon his return to the club, he scored and revealed an undershirt with the words "Freedom for Papa" printed in Spanish.

A look at how FIFA World Cup 2026 stars young and old are faring after first week

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ New York

Cape Verde's 40-year-old goalkeeper has become a star at this World Cup, and a Senegal teenager scored in his tournament debut.

Here's a look at some of the oldest and youngest players as the 48-team tournament enters its second week.

Elder statesmen

No better place to begin than the 41-year-old Cristiano



Ronaldo. The Portugal star will be disappointed to not have found the back of the net in a 1-1 draw with Congo on Wednesday. FIFA said Ronaldo became the oldest outfield player to start a World Cup match.

Luka Modric, 40, led Croatia to the 2018 World Cup final but got off to a rough start against England o



Wednesday, when his foul led to Harry Kane's penalty goal. The midfielder great was subbed off before the hour mark in a 4-2 loss.

There are several 40-year-old goalkeepers on World Cup rosters. Manuel Neuer of Germany might be the best known of the bunch, but Cape Verde's Vozinha has joined the chat. The unheralded goalkeeper played a big role in holding Spain to a 0-0 draw. His mom hopes to be at their next match - Sunday against Uruguay in Miami.

Lionel Messi is a sprightly 38 - he turns 39 next week - and dazzled in Argentina's opener



by scoring a hat trick against Algeria.

Young guns: Mexico teenager Gilberto Mora got a big cheer from the home fans when he entered as a substitute in the second half of El Tri's 2-0 victory over South Africa. The 17-year-old midfielder, the youngest player on the World Cup rosters, plays for Tijuana in Liga MX and is being tracked by several top European clubs.

Mexico faces South Korea on Thursday in Guadalajara.

Senegal forward Ibrahim Mbaye made an immedi-

ate impact in his World Cup debut. The 18-year-old French-born Mbaye came on in the 75th minute against France and scored in stoppage time of their 3-1 loss to Kylian Mbappe and company. Senegal will play Norway on Monday.

Ayyoub Bouaddi, 18, stood out in the midfield for Morocco in its 1-1 draw with Brazil. The teenager played for France at youth level but switched to Morocco just in time for the World Cup. Egypt forward Hamza Abdelkarim, 18, came on as sub in 1-1 draw with Belgium, replacing star Mohamed Salah in 76th minute. The biggest of young guns is Spain's Lamine Yamal, who turns 19 next month. He only returned from a hamstring injury and was pressed into action as a sub in Spain's draw with Cape Verde.

Domestic cricket nurtured me for international stage: Gurnoor

APARAJITA UPADHYAY ■ Lucknow

India's newest pace sensation Gurnoor Brar believes his seamless transition to international cricket is the result of years spent honing his skills in domestic cricket and the exposure he gained through the India A set-up before stepping onto the biggest stage.

The Punjab fast bowler has impressed with his pace and control in his debut ODI series against Afghanistan.

"The India A setup is obviously a big thing for me. If we perform in the Ranji Trophy, we get picked for India A, the Duleep Trophy or the Irani Cup. When I got the call-up for India A, I was very happy," Brar said after India's series-clinching 170-run win.

The 26-year-old has been one of India's stand-out performers in the series, troubling batters with his pace, bounce and ability to execute yorkers under pressure. He has



picked six wickets in 15.5 overs across the two ODIs.

"It was the same for me as when I bowled in Ranji, bowling fast, hitting a hard length and swinging the ball. I tried to replicate the exact same thing in India A and hit the same lines."

A towering presence at six feet five, Brar is known to be a "hit the deck" bowler, rattling batters with short deliveries. "I don't think about that (reputation) much. I believe in myself and whatever I am doing, whether it is hard length or fast-paced bowling, I tried to replicate that here as well."

Despite his encouraging start, Brar feels he has only scratched the surface of his potential. "In these two matches, I wanted to do better from my end. I know that I can do better than I bowled today. Hopefully, in the coming matches, I will be better."

Brar, who spent the recent IPL season warming



the bench in Gujarat Titans, credited the quality of bowlers around him for accelerating his growth as a fast bowler.

"There is a very good atmosphere in GT. There is (Ashish) Nehra sir, (Kagiso) Rabada, (Mohammed) Siraj bhai, Prasidh (Krishna) bhai and Ishant Sharma, so you get to learn a lot from them. Obviously, every player wants to get a chance to play, and I was also waiting for my

chance there. "But at the same time, I was observing where they were making mistakes and where they were doing well. For me, it was about how much more I could learn so that when I got my chance, I could do better."

"I am thankful to God that I got my chance to show what I can do with India." Brar's effectiveness at the death has been among the highlights of his

performances, with the youngster placing significant emphasis on mastering yorkers. "According to me, every fast bowler should work on yorkers. I work on my death bowling to see how consistently I can bowl yorkers because when you have to bowl at the death, yorkers are very useful, especially when good hitters come in."

He said the support from the Indian

team management has helped him bowl with greater freedom.

"The management and bowling coach back me a lot, which gives me the chance to bowl more openly. They didn't give me any new tips; they just told me to back my strength."

Brar added that white-ball bowling was as much about planning and variation as outright speed.

"You can't just bowl fast. Many batsmen like pace if there is nothing in the wicket. It becomes about how we plan against a good opposition or a good batsman and how we set our field positions." The pacer also spoke about the importance of adapting his lengths according to conditions.

"If your outswing is good, every batsman faces problems, so I try to swing it as much as I can. When the swing is less, I push my length back."

He cited the conditions in the second ODI, where the scorching heat reduced any assistance for swing bowlers.

"The ball wasn't swinging much due to the heat and the wicket. So we adjusted the plan. If we don't get swing, we put the ball back. It all works according to the batsman, the wicket, and the match situation." (PTI)

BCCI eyes Mar 10 to May 15 IPL window amid heat concerns: Devajit Saikia



KUSHAN SARKAR ■ New Delhi

In its bid to beat the extreme May heat in most parts of the country, the BCCI is contemplating an early start to the IPL, eyeing a March 10-May 15 window for future editions starting next year. Board secretary Devajit Saikia told PTI in an exclusive interview. However, he made it clear that due to international calendar constraints, the number of matches will remain 74 and not be increased to 94.

The IPL usually gets underway in the last week of March and winds up towards the end of May. Saikia said an early IPL would protect the interest of both players as well as the paying public.

"This year, IPL started around the March 29th (28th), and it was over by May 31. Only thing which we are discussing is that during the fog end of the tournament after May 15...there is apprehension of having rainfall or pre-monsoon season starting."

"On the other hand, there is hot weather which is not very conducive either for the players or for the crowds," Saikia said in the interaction.

He said the BCCI is working on advancing the itinerary by two weeks to beat the rising mercury during the latter part of May.

"So therefore, there is a discussion going on in BCCI as well as in our IPL Governing Council regarding whether we can start the tournament a little bit earlier than the fog end of March," he said.

"From next year, we will make an effort and I have already instructed our General Manager (Games Development) (former pacer Abbey Kuruvilla) to look for the windows whether we can start it by 10th of March and conclude it by 15th of May. So that there are no adverse weather conditions in the run-up to the playoff and the finals of the IPL 2027 which will be the 20th edition," Saikia informed. (PTI)



KRISTIE RIEKENAP ■ Houston

Cristiano Ronaldo delivered a pretty forgettable performance in the first match of his sixth World Cup.

After Lionel Messi, Kylian Mbappe and Erling Haaland all scored in their opening matches, the 41-year-old Ronaldo couldn't find the net Wednesday in Portugal's 1-1 draw with Congo.

With players like Vinicius Junior, Christian Pulisic, Viktor Gyokeres and Harry Kane also all scoring early in this year's World Cup, Ronaldo being held scoreless stands out even more.

However, the Portugal great did join Messi as the only players to appear in six World



Cups. But a day after the Argentina captain had a hat trick, Ronaldo missed a few chances to become the first player to score in a sixth tournament.

His shots in the 68th and 73rd minutes went wide right, and he didn't look happy after either of them.

Ronaldo didn't speak to reporters after the game but he

BCCI wants Vaibhav's parents on tour to ease him into senior team environment: BCCI Secy Saikia

KUSHAN SARKAR ■ New Delhi

A 15-year-old schoolboy needs to be eased into a senior team set-up, said BCCI Secretary Devajit Saikia as he explained the Board's decision to allow Vaibhav Sooryavanshi's parents to accompany him on the white-ball tour of Ireland and England later this month.



The big-hitting Sooryavanshi, who has earned his maiden call-up in the Indian T20 set-up, has been selected for seven games (two vs Ireland and five vs England) on the tour which begins on June 26 in Belfast.

"You see, not all national teams at the senior level have a 14 or 15-year-old in their squad. After many decades, we have someone like Vaibhav Sooryavanshi," Saikia told PTI in an exclusive interview.

"At one point in time, it was Sachin Tendulkar (16 and half at time of Test debut) who made it to the national team at such a young age. When such a young



kid is part of the senior team, there are obviously a lot of issues that can crop up," he added without elaborating.

"Therefore, to make him comfortable and help him get used to an adult environment, where all the other players are above 18 years of age, and the team management members are also adults, we felt it would be helpful," Saikia, a former Ranji Trophy player for Assam, stated further. "We are doing this because we believe it will ease a lot of issues as far as Vaibhav is concerned."

Saikia cited the example of how senior teachers accompany students on school excursions. "Even when a school student goes on an excursion, there is usually a senior person accompanying them. Vaibhav is still a kid. He has only just come out of school, or is perhaps in his final year of school.

"So, we thought it proper to allow his parents to travel with him. I am very happy that his parents are also taking good care of their kid, who is an asset for Indian cricket not only now but for

the next two or three decades," he added.

"BCCI is not match referee": Saikia was also surprised to see social media speculation that the Indian board will take action against Sooryavanshi for his heated on-field exchange with Sri Lanka A team player Vishen Halambage during a recent A match. After a provocative comment from the Sri Lankan, there was an argument following which Sooryavanshi pushed Halambage when he came near the Indian. "A lot of things are going on in the social media that BCCI is contemplating action, etc. Do you want BCCI to step into the domain of match referee?" Saikia counter-quested.

"The BCCI is not an authority, we should not intrude into the area where the match referee and the umpires are the main persons who can take any decision regarding any incident that had happened in the playground.

"Whatever had happened, it was a part of the game, and the BCCI have no role to play. The role is of the match referee. If anything is going wrong, he will take a call, the umpires will take a call, and there is a system in place," the eminent lawyer said. (PTI)

Caleb Yirenki's late goal gives Ghana 1-0 victory over Panama in World Cup

OWEN CAMEROS ■ Toronto

Caleb Yirenki tapped in a cross from Brandon Thomas-Asante in the fifth minute of second-half stoppage time, and Ghana beat Panama 1-0 on Wednesday night in the teams' World Cup opener.

At the end of a game that saw few chances for either side, Thomas-Asante got loose on the left side and fired the ball across the goal mouth. Yirenki knocked it in, sending his teammates streaming onto the field.

Ghana played without midfielder Thomas Partey, who was denied entry into Canada while he awaits trial on rape charges in England.

The late goal denied Panama its first



World Cup point. The only shot on goal in the first half came two minutes in, when Panama forward

Cecilio Waterman latched onto a low cross from Amir Murillo and clipped a ball from the center of the box toward the net. Ati-Zigi dove to his right and palmed the ball away.

The goalkeeper left the game at half-time after bearing the brunt of a couple of hard collisions. (AP)

Harry Kane ties England's record for World Cup goals in 4-2 win over Croatia

SCHUYLER DIXONAP

■ Arlington (US)

Harry Kane scored twice to equal the English record for World Cup goals, Jude Bellingham added another two minutes into the second half and England beat Croatia 4-2 on Wednesday.

Martin Baturina and Petar Musa answered each of Kane's first-half goals in a rematch of the 2018 semifinal game won by Croatia. Musa's goal came on the final play before the whistle ending the first half. Bellingham took a long pass and stayed clear of the defender the rest of the way, sending a shot past Dominik Livakovic and in off the far post. Marcus Rashford



padded the lead in the 85th minute. Kane, who won the Golden Boot at the 2018 World Cup in Russia by scoring six times, is up to 10 World Cup goals, tying Gary Lineker's mark from the 1986 and 1990 tournaments.

The 32-year-old striker's first goal came on his second chance on a penalty kick after Livakovic's save on the first try was nullified by a video review that showed both his feet off the goal line as Kane was striking the ball. (AP)